

# **THE LIGHT WITHIN**

## **Letting Christ Shine in Every Room of Your Life**

By

Abass Kyeremeh

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### **DEDICATION**

To the One who spoke light into existence and then placed that light within this earthen vessel—this book is Your breath on paper.

## TABLE OF CONTENTS

| CHAPTER  | TITLE                    |
|----------|--------------------------|
| 1.....   | The Light You Carry      |
| 2.....   | Hidden No More           |
| 3 .....  | The Flame and the Vessel |
| 4.....   | When Darkness Intrudes   |
| 5 .....  | Fuel for the Journey     |
| 6.....   | Reflections of Glory     |
| 7.....   | Walking in the Light     |
| 8.....   | Lamps to the Lost        |
| 9.....   | The Community of Light   |
| 10.....  | Guardians of the Flame   |
| 11.....  | Shining Through Storms   |
| 12 ..... | Until the Morning Comes  |

## PREFACE

Every book has a story behind it. Not just the story printed on its pages, but the story of how those pages came to be. This is the story of *The Light Within*.

I did not set out to write a book. I set out to understand something. For years, I lived with a nagging question that would not leave me: If Christ truly lives within every believer, why do so many of us live as if He were still a distant figure? We sing about the light. We read about the light. We nod our heads when preachers speak about the light. But somehow, the glow of our lives seems dim compared to the blazing fire described in Scripture.

This question followed me through quiet mornings, through sleepless nights, through seasons of success and seasons of failure. It followed me into the classrooms of Okomfo Anokye Senior High School, where I first began to wrestle with deep things under the guidance of teachers who saw something in me I had not yet seen in myself. It followed me into the sanctuary, where pastors poured truth into my spirit. It followed me into the quiet moments with my mother, whose own life radiated a light she probably never knew she carried.

What you hold in your hands is not the result of academic research alone. It is the product of life. It is what I have learned sitting at the feet of Scripture, standing in the company of the saints, and walking through the valleys and mountains of my own journey with God.

The title, *The Light Within*, speaks to the great mystery that Paul called "Christ in you, the hope of glory." But this book is not content to leave that truth in the realm of theology. It insists on asking the practical question: So what? If Christ is in me, how should I treat my spouse? How should I show up at work on Monday morning? How should I respond when life crushes me? How should I raise my children? How should I speak to the stranger at the market?

These are the questions we will explore together. And I do mean together. A book is a conversation, not a lecture. As you read, I invite you to dialogue with me on these pages. Argue with me if you must. Wrestle with the Scriptures I cite. Test everything against the Word and against your own experience with God. But do not read passively. Reading a book like this is like lighting a candle from another flame, it requires proximity, attention, and a willingness to catch fire.

I have written this book with a specific reader in mind: the believer who knows they are called to more but feels stuck in the gap between promise and reality. The one who carries the light within but wonders why their corner of the world remains so dark. The one who wants their life to count but doesn't know where to begin.

If that is you, then this book is your invitation. Not to try harder, but to see clearer. Not to manufacture light, but to remove everything that hides the light already within you. Not to become someone else, but to become fully who you already are in Christ.

The journey begins now. Turn the page, and let us walk together into the light.

Abass Kyeremeh

## ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

No book is written in isolation. Words are born in community, shaped by relationship, and refined through the influence of those who have gone before us. This book, though my name appears on the cover, carries the imprint of many hands and hearts.

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To all my basic school teachers, who labored with little recognition and even less pay to plant the seeds of knowledge in young minds. You taught me to read, to write, to think. You corrected my mistakes with patience and celebrated my progress with joy. You saw potential in a boy who did not yet know what potential meant. I stand on your shoulders.

To Okomfo Anokye Senior High School, the institution that shaped not only my mind but my character. Within your walls, I learned to dream beyond my circumstances. Within your classrooms, I discovered that I could wrestle with deep questions and find answers. I am forever grateful for the foundation you laid in my life.

And to Mr. Osei Kofi Michael, I owe a special debt of gratitude. You were more than a teacher; you were a mentor, a guide, and a believer in possibilities I could not yet see. Your dedication to excellence, your patience with my questions, and your unwavering commitment to seeing students succeed left an indelible mark on my life. Sir, the seeds you planted are still bearing fruit. Thank you.

To my pastors, who have fed me with the Word of God and tended to my soul through every season:

- Rev. Peter Asare Asamoah, your teaching opened the Scriptures to me in ways I never imagined possible. You model what it means to handle the Word with accuracy and reverence.
- Rev. Bernard Acheampong, your fatherly heart and patient shepherding have guided me through many difficult waters. You never gave up on me, even when I was hard to pastor.

· Rev. Joseph Amoako, your passion for the presence of God ignited something in my spirit that has never gone out. You taught me that the light within must be continually fueled by intimacy with the Source.

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To all my siblings, my first friends and my lifelong companions. We have laughed together, cried together, fought together, and grown together. You know me in ways the world never will, and you love me anyway. Thank you for your patience with me, your belief in me, and your constant encouragement. This family is one of God's greatest gifts to me.

And to you, the reader. You who have chosen to invest your time and attention in these pages. You who are seeking, struggling, hoping, believing. You are the reason I wrote. May the light within you burn brighter with every page you turn.

# CHAPTER ONE

## The Light You Carry

"You are the light of the world. A city that is set on a hill cannot be hidden." — Matthew 5:14 (NKJV)

There are some statements that are so familiar we cease to hear them. They roll off the tongue with practiced ease. We nod along when they are quoted. We underline them in our Bibles. But somewhere along the way, the shock of them wears off, and we lose the wonder they were meant to inspire.

Jesus' declaration that we are the light of the world is one such statement. It has been repeated so often, in so many sermons and Sunday school lessons, that we have become numb to its audacity. We have forgotten how outrageous it would have sounded to the original hearers. We have lost the sense of holy impossibility that should accompany these words.

Consider who Jesus was speaking to. Not to the religious elite. Not to the scholars and scribes. Not to those who had their theology perfected and their lives in order. He was speaking to a ragtag collection of fishermen, tax collectors, and ordinary people. He was speaking to men who would, within hours of His arrest, flee in fear and deny knowing Him. He was speaking to people just like you and me flawed, fearful, and far from perfect.

And to these people, He said: You are the light of the world.

Not you might become. Not you could be if you try hard enough. Not you will be after years of spiritual development. You are. Present tense. Declarative statement. Divine pronouncement.

Before they had done anything noteworthy, before they had preached a single sermon or performed a single miracle, before they had proven themselves in any way, Jesus looked at ordinary people and declared them to be light.

### The Source of the Light

This is crucial for us to understand, because if we miss it, we will spend our lives striving for something we already possess. We will exhaust ourselves trying to become what we already are. We will chase a destination we reached the moment we were born again.

The light you carry is not your own. You did not generate it. You cannot sustain it by your own effort. It is not the product of your personality, your goodness, or your spiritual discipline. It is something given, not achieved. It is a gift, not a wage.

### **Paul makes this clear in his second letter to the Corinthians:**

"For it is the God who commanded light to shine out of darkness, who has shone in our hearts to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ" (2 Corinthians 4:6).

Notice the parallel. The same God who spoke light into existence at the dawn of creation has spoken light into your heart. The creative power that pushed back the primordial darkness now resides within you. The light that brought order out of chaos now brings order to your chaos and, through you, to the chaos around you.

This is not metaphor. This is not poetry designed to make you feel good about yourself. This is spiritual reality. If you are in Christ, you carry within you the very light of God. You are, as Paul writes elsewhere, "light in the Lord" (Ephesians 5:8).

The implications of this truth are staggering. It means that you are never alone, even when you feel alone. It means that you never face darkness without resources, even when you feel empty. It means that you carry within you the answer to the world's deepest need, even when you feel inadequate.

### **The Nature of Light**

To understand what it means to be light, we must understand something about light itself. Light has certain properties that reveal what our role in the world should be.

First, light is self-revealing. You do not have to tell a candle to shine; you simply have to light it. You do not have to instruct the sun to rise; you simply have to remove whatever is blocking its rays. Light, by its very nature, cannot help but reveal itself.

This means that your primary job is not to manufacture light but to remove whatever hides it. Your job is not to become something you are not but to uncover what you already are. The light is within you. Your task is to let it shine.

Second, light exposes. Whatever is hidden becomes visible when light enters. This is why people who walk in darkness often avoid the light. They prefer to keep their deeds concealed. But this is



also why the world needs people who carry light. Without us, darkness remains unchallenged. Without us, evil goes unnamed. Without us, sin hides in the shadows.

When you let your light shine, you will inevitably expose things that people prefer to keep hidden. This will not always make you popular. But popularity is not your calling. Faithfulness is.

Third, light guides. A lamp on a dark path shows the way forward. A lighthouse on a rocky coast warns of danger and points to safety. In a world filled with confusion and uncertainty, those who carry light become guides for those who have lost their way.

You may not feel qualified to guide anyone. You may feel that your own path is uncertain enough. But the light you carry is not your own wisdom or your own understanding. It is the light of Christ. And that light is sufficient for any path, any confusion, any uncertainty.

Fourth, light attracts. Have you ever noticed how moths gather around a flame? Have you ever seen how people are drawn to a fire on a cold night? Light has an attractive quality. It pulls things toward itself.

When you carry the light of Christ, you will attract people. Not because you are charming or charismatic, but because the light within you meets a deep need in those who live in darkness. They may not understand what draws them. They may not be able to articulate what they are seeking. But they will be drawn to the light you carry.

### **The Tragedy of Hidden Light**

Given all that light is and does, the tragedy of hidden light becomes clear. Jesus spoke directly to this tragedy:

"Nor do they light a lamp and put it under a basket, but on a lampstand, and it gives light to all who are in the house" (Matthew 5:15).

The imagery is almost absurd. Who would go to the trouble of lighting a lamp only to cover it? Who would kindle a flame only to hide it? The very act of lighting implies the intention to illuminate. A lamp that is hidden defeats its own purpose.

Yet this absurdity plays out in the lives of countless believers every single day. We have been lit by the Spirit of God. We carry within us the light of the knowledge of God's glory. But we hide that light under the basket of fear, under the basket of busyness, under the basket of comfort, under the basket of compromise.

We hide our light because we are afraid of what people will think. We hide our light because we do not want to stand out. We hide our light because shining requires effort and attention and

sacrifice. We hide our light because the darkness is comfortable and the light exposes things we would rather not see.

But a hidden light is no light at all. A lamp under a basket gives light to no one. It heats nothing. It guides no one. It exposes nothing. It is, for all practical purposes, useless.

## **The Weight of the Declaration**

When Jesus said, "You are the light of the world," He was not offering a suggestion. He was not presenting an option. He was declaring a fact and, in that declaration, issuing a summons.

The world does not have many lights. It has many people who claim to have answers, many philosophies that promise illumination, many systems that offer guidance. But the true light—the light that exposes, guides, attracts, and reveals—comes from only one source. And that source has chosen to place His light in you.

This means that people in your sphere of influence will either encounter the light of Christ or remain in darkness based on your willingness to shine. Your family, your friends, your coworkers, your neighbors, they are depending on you, whether they know it or not. The light you carry is their only hope of seeing clearly.

This is a weighty responsibility. It would be overwhelming if the light were your own. But it is not. It is Christ's light, carried in your vessel, shining through your life. Your job is simply to get out of the way, to remove the basket, to let what is within come forth.

## **The Personal Question**

As we begin this journey together, I want to ask you a personal question: What basket are you hiding under?

Is it fear? Are you afraid of what people will think if you speak about your faith? Are you afraid of being rejected, mocked, or misunderstood?

Is it busyness? Are you so consumed with the demands of daily life that you have no energy left to shine? Have you allowed the urgent to crowd out the important?

Is it comfort? Are you so comfortable with the way things are that you have no desire to rock the boat? Have you settled for a quiet life when you were made for a significant one?

Is it compromise? Are there areas of your life that do not align with the light you carry? Are you hiding the light because you are afraid it will expose your own darkness?

Whatever the basket, it can be removed. Whatever hides your light can be lifted. The light within you is still there, still burning, still waiting to shine. The question is whether you will let it.

### **A Light Like No Other**

Before we move on, I want you to sit with the wonder of what you carry. You are not just any light. You are not a dim glow or a flickering flame. You are a carrier of the very light of God.

The same light that blinded Paul on the road to Damascus. The same light that filled the tabernacle in the wilderness. The same light that led Israel through the desert by night. The same light that shone from the face of Moses after he had been in God's presence. That light is within you.

It may feel small at times. It may flicker when storms arise. It may seem insignificant compared to the darkness around you. But do not be deceived. The smallest light pierces darkness. The faintest glow changes the atmosphere. A single candle can fill an entire room with illumination.

You are that candle. You are that light. And the world needs you to shine.

### **Prayer for the Journey**

Father of lights, I thank You that You have shone in my heart to give the light of the knowledge of Your glory. I thank You that I am not destined for darkness but created for illumination. I thank You that the same light that spoke creation into existence now dwells within me.

Lord, I confess that I have hidden my light. I have covered it with fear, with busyness, with comfort, with compromise. Forgive me. Cleanse me. Give me courage to remove the basket and let Your light shine through me without hindrance.

Show me the people who need my light. Give me opportunities to shine. And when those opportunities come, fill me with Your Spirit so that I may not shrink back but step forward in faith.

I am Yours. Use me. Shine through me. Let the light within me push back the darkness around me. In Jesus' name, Amen.

# CHAPTER TWO

## Hidden No More

"For you were once darkness, but now you are light in the Lord. Walk as children of light." — Ephesians 5:8 (NKJV)

There is a phrase in the English language that captures something deep about the human experience: living a double life. It speaks of the gap between who we appear to be and who we actually are. It describes the exhausting work of maintaining a facade, of projecting one image while harboring another, of smiling on the outside while crumbling on the inside.

Most of us know something about this. We have learned, through years of practice, to hide the parts of ourselves we do not want others to see. We hide our fears behind bravado. We hide our insecurities behind achievement. We hide our pain behind smiles. We hide our doubts behind religious language.

But hiding takes a toll. It costs energy to maintain the facade. It costs relationships to keep people at a distance. It costs peace to constantly watch what we say and do. And worst of all, it costs us the experience of being fully known and fully loved.

Paul's words to the Ephesians cut through this entire dynamic with surgical precision: "For you were once darkness, but now you are light in the Lord."

Notice he does not say, "You were once in darkness." He says, "You were once darkness." The distinction is crucial. Being in darkness describes your environment; being darkness describes your identity. Before Christ, you were not just surrounded by darkness; you were part of it. Darkness was not something outside you; it was something within you. It defined you, shaped you, characterized you.

But now, everything has changed. You are no longer darkness; you are light. Not just in light, but light. Your identity has been fundamentally transformed. The core of your being has been rewired. The old has passed away; the new has come.

And because you are light, you are called to walk as children of light. The imperative is based on the indicative. You do not walk as light in order to become light; you walk as light because you are light. Your behavior flows from your identity, not the other way around.

## The Great Exchange

To understand the transformation Paul describes, we must understand what happened at salvation. Something far more profound than a mere decision or a change of behavior took place. A supernatural exchange occurred.

### **Paul describes it this way:**

"He has delivered us from the power of darkness and conveyed us into the kingdom of the Son of His love" (Colossians 1:13).

The word conveyed is rich with meaning. It speaks of being transferred, relocated, moved from one domain to another. It is the language of citizenship, of changing allegiance, of shifting from the rule of darkness to the rule of light.

Before Christ, you were under the power of darkness. You may not have realized it. You may have thought you were free, making your own choices, living your own life. But you were under a power, a force that shaped your thinking, influenced your desires, and directed your steps. Darkness had dominion over you.

But when you came to Christ, something happened. You were delivered from that power. The chains were broken. The dominion was ended. You were transferred, relocated, rehomed, replanted into the kingdom of light.

This is not metaphor. This is spiritual reality. You are no longer under the authority of darkness. You are under a new authority, a new rule, a new King. And that King is light.

### **The Problem of Remnant Darkness**

If all this is true, why do we still struggle? Why do we still sin? Why do we still have thoughts and desires that contradict our identity as light?

This is one of the most pressing questions of the Christian life. And the answer, while simple, requires careful understanding.

Although your identity has been changed, your experience is still being transformed. You are light in your spirit, but your soul—your mind, will, and emotions—is being renewed day by day. You have been delivered from the power of darkness, but you still carry the residue of your time in darkness. Old habits, old thought patterns, old wounds, old lies—these do not disappear overnight.

### **Paul describes this tension in his letter to the Romans:**

"I find then a law, that evil is present with me, the one who wills to do good. For I delight in the law of God according to the inward man. But I see another law in my members, warring against the law of my mind, and bringing me into captivity to the law of sin which is in my members" (Romans 7:21-23).

Notice the war language. Paul describes a conflict between the inward man—the new creation, the light within—and the members of his body, the old patterns that still reside in his flesh. The war is real. The conflict is intense. But the outcome is certain.

The light within you is stronger than the remnant darkness. The new creation is more powerful than the old habits. The Spirit who raised Christ from the dead dwells in you and is progressively working to bring every part of your being into alignment with your new identity.

### **The Call to Walk**

Because of this tension between identity and experience, we are called to walk. Not to sit passively, waiting for transformation to happen automatically. Not to strive anxiously, trying to manufacture change through our own effort. But to walk—steadily, intentionally, step by step—as children of light.

Walking implies progress. It implies direction. It implies effort. But it also implies dependence. A walker is not running, not sprinting, not exhausting themselves in frantic activity. A walker is moving at a sustainable pace, trusting that each step builds on the one before.

What does it mean to walk as children of light? Paul gives us specific instructions in the verses that follow:

"For the fruit of the Spirit is in all goodness, righteousness, and truth, finding out what is acceptable to the Lord. And have no fellowship with the unfruitful works of darkness, but rather expose them" (Ephesians 5:9-11).

Walking as light means producing fruit—goodness, righteousness, truth. It means living in a way that pleases the Lord, not just in big decisions but in the small, daily choices that make up a life. It means refusing to partner with darkness, refusing to participate in deeds that belong to the night. And it means exposing darkness—not in a spirit of judgment or self-righteousness, but in a spirit of truth and love.

This last point is crucial. Light exposes by its very nature. You do not have to go looking for darkness to condemn; you simply have to shine, and darkness is automatically exposed. Your job is not to be the judge but to be the light. Let the light shine, and let the light do what light does.

## **The Freedom of Being Known**

One of the greatest benefits of walking as light is the freedom that comes from being fully known. When you stop hiding, when you stop maintaining the facade, when you allow your life to be illuminated by the light of Christ, something liberating happens.

You discover that you are loved anyway. You discover that the things you feared would disqualify you are covered by grace. You discover that vulnerability, far from being a weakness, is a gateway to deeper relationship.

### **The apostle John writes about this:**

"But if we walk in the light as He is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus Christ His Son cleanses us from all sin" (1 John 1:7).

Notice the connection between walking in light and having fellowship. When we hide, we isolate. When we conceal, we separate. But when we walk in the light—when we live authentically, honestly, transparently—we create the conditions for genuine fellowship. We discover that we are not alone in our struggles. We find that others have walked the same paths. We experience the healing that comes from being known and accepted.

### **This is why confession is so powerful. James writes:**

"Confess your trespasses to one another, and pray for one another, that you may be healed" (James 5:16).

Confession brings hidden things into the light. And when hidden things are exposed to the light, healing becomes possible. The secrets that have festered in darkness begin to lose their power. The shame that has thrived in secrecy begins to dissolve. The chains that have bound us in isolation begin to break.

## **The Practice of Transparency**

Walking as light is not something that happens automatically. It requires intention. It requires practice. It requires choices that go against our natural inclination to hide.

Here are some practical steps toward greater transparency:

First, practice honesty with yourself. Many of us hide from ourselves before we hide from others. We deny our feelings. We minimize our struggles. We rationalize our sins. The first step toward

walking in light is to stop lying to ourselves. Look honestly at your heart. Acknowledge what you find there, even if it is uncomfortable.

Second, practice honesty with God. You cannot hide from God anyway. He knows everything—every thought, every motive, every secret desire. But there is something powerful about bringing those things into conscious conversation with Him. Tell Him what you are feeling. Confess what you have done. Ask for what you need. Prayer is not about informing God; it is about aligning yourself with His reality.

Third, practice honesty with trusted others. Not everyone deserves to know your secrets. Wisdom requires discernment about who to trust. But everyone needs someone with whom they can be fully honest. Find a safe person, a mentor, a friend, a counselor and begin to let them see the real you. Start with small things and see how it feels. Gradually, as trust grows, let them see more.

Fourth, practice honesty in your daily life. This does not mean sharing everything with everyone. That would be unwise and inappropriate. But it does mean living with integrity—letting your words match your actions, letting your public life match your private life, letting your yes be yes and your no be no.

### **The Promise of Increase**

As you walk in the light, as you live transparently before God and others, something remarkable happens. The light within you grows brighter. It becomes more consistent. It influences more of your life and more of the lives around you.

### **Jesus spoke of this principle:**

"For whoever has, to him more will be given; but whoever does not have, even what he has will be taken away from him" (Mark 4:25).

This sounds harsh until we understand what it means. The "having" Jesus refers to is not about possessions but about responsiveness. Those who respond to the light they have been given will receive more light. Those who ignore or hide the light they have will lose even what they have.

This is the principle of increase. Light obeyed leads to more light. Truth embraced leads to more truth. Transparency practiced leads to greater capacity for transparency.

As you walk in the light, you will find that areas of your life that were once dark become illuminated. Patterns you could not see become visible. Sins you could not overcome become conquerable. Relationships that were shallow become deep. .



## **Hidden No More**

You were made for more than hiding. You were made for more than maintaining a facade. You were made for more than living a double life.

You were made to be light. Not just to carry light, but to be light. Not just to have light within, but to have light all through in every thought, every word, every action, every relationship.

The journey from hidden to revealed is not easy. It requires courage. It requires trust. It requires letting go of the false selves we have constructed and embracing the true self God created.

But the reward is worth the cost. Freedom awaits on the other side of hiding. Connection awaits on the other side of concealment. Purpose awaits on the other side of pretense.

You were hidden long enough. Now, walk as a child of light.

## **Prayer for the Journey**

Lord of light, I thank You that I am no longer darkness but light in You. I thank You that You have delivered me from the power of darkness and transferred me into Your kingdom. I thank You that my identity is forever changed.

Father, I confess that I still hide. I hide from myself, from others, and even from You. Fear of rejection, fear of judgment, fear of exposure keeps me in the shadows. Give me courage to step into the light.

Show me the safe people with whom I can be honest. Give me wisdom to know who to trust and what to share. And as I step into greater transparency, let Your light fill more and more of my life.

I am Yours. Shape me. Heal me. Make me fully light, as You are light. In Jesus' name, Amen.

# CHAPTER THREE

## The Flame and the Vessel

"But we have this treasure in earthen vessels, that the excellence of the power may be of God and not of us." — 2 Corinthians 4:7 (NKJV)

There is a tension at the heart of the Christian life that we cannot escape. It is the tension between the greatness of what we carry and the ordinariness of who we are. It is the tension between the treasure and the vessel, between the flame and the container, between the divine and the human.

Paul captures this tension perfectly in one of the most profound verses in all of Scripture. He has just spoken of the light that God has shone in our hearts—the treasure of divine revelation, the glory of knowing Christ, the very presence of God within us. Then, in verse seven, he introduces the container that holds this treasure: earthen vessels.

The Greek word for earthen vessels is *ostrakinos skeuos*. It refers to something made of clay, something common, something fragile, something replaceable. In the ancient world, clay pots were the everyday containers of ordinary life. They were cheap. They were breakable. They were everywhere. When one cracked, you threw it away and got another.

This is what Paul says we are. Not golden chalices. Not silver platters. Not ornate vessels worthy of the treasure they contain. Just clay pots. Common. Fragile. Ordinary.

And yet, within these ordinary clay pots, we carry the most extraordinary treasure imaginable: the light of the knowledge of God's glory. The flame of divine presence. The very life of Christ.

## The Purpose of the Paradox

Why does God do it this way? Why does He place His priceless treasure in such breakable containers? Why does He entrust His glorious light to such ordinary people?

**Paul gives us the answer: "that the excellence of the power may be of God and not of us."**

God designs it this way so that no one will confuse the vessel with the treasure. He wants it unmistakably clear that any good that comes from our lives, any light that shines through us, any power that flows from us is His and not ours. He wants the glory to go where it belongs.

If we were golden vessels, people would admire the container. They would be impressed by our eloquence, our charisma, our wisdom, our strength. They would attribute the light to the vessel.

But because we are clay, ordinary, fragile, unimpressive clay—there is no mistaking where the power comes from. When light shines through a cracked pot, everyone knows the light is not from the pot.

This is humbling, but it is also liberating. It means we do not have to be impressive. We do not have to be perfect. We do not have to have it all together. We just have to be willing vessels, open containers through which the light of Christ can shine.

### **The Honesty of Clay**

One of the great burdens of the Christian life is the pressure to appear stronger than we are. We feel we must project an image of having everything under control. We must hide our struggles, mask our doubts, cover our failures. We must present ourselves as polished, put-together, perfect.

But clay pots are not polished. They are not put-together. They are not perfect. They are ordinary. They are common. They are, in many ways, unremarkable.

There is freedom in accepting that we are clay. There is freedom in admitting that we are fragile. There is freedom in acknowledging that we crack under pressure, that we chip when bumped, that we sometimes leak.

The Psalms are full of this kind of honesty. David, a man after God's own heart, did not hide his struggles. He poured them out before God with raw transparency:

"Be merciful to me, O Lord, for I am in distress; my eyes grow weak with sorrow, my soul and my body with grief. My life is consumed by anguish and my years by groaning; my strength fails because of my affliction, and my bones grow weak" (Psalm 31:9-10).

This is not the language of someone trying to appear strong. This is the language of clay—fragile, honest, real. And yet, this same David carried the light of God. This same David wrote some of the most glorious praises in Scripture. This same David was called a man after God's own heart.

The honesty of clay does not disqualify us from carrying the treasure. It actually makes us more suitable vessels, because it keeps us dependent on the One whose power is made perfect in weakness.

### **The Cracks That Let Light Out**

There is another aspect of this metaphor that we must not miss. Paul speaks of earthen vessels, but he also speaks elsewhere of being "hard pressed on every side, yet not crushed; perplexed,

but not in despair; persecuted, but not forsaken; struck down, but not destroyed" (2 Corinthians 4:8-9).

The picture is of vessels under pressure. Clay pots that are being squeezed, battered, tested. And in that pressure, cracks appear. The vessel is not destroyed, but it is certainly damaged.

Here is the mystery: those cracks are not just places where the vessel is weakened. They are also places where the light gets out.

Think about it. A perfect, unblemished vessel would contain the light completely. The treasure would be inside, but no one would see it. The vessel would be intact, but the light would be hidden. It takes cracks—places of brokenness, places of pressure, places of pain—for the light to escape and illuminate the world around.

This is not to say that sin is good or that brokenness is desirable. But it is to say that God, in His redemptive wisdom, can use our very cracks to display His glory. The places where we have been broken become the places where His light shines brightest.

Paul understood this personally. He had a "thorn in the flesh"—some ongoing weakness or trial that he begged God to remove. But God's response was unexpected:

"My grace is sufficient for you, for My strength is made perfect in weakness" (2 Corinthians 12:9).

### **Paul's response to this revelation is remarkable:**

"Therefore most gladly I will rather boast in my infirmities, that the power of Christ may rest upon me. Therefore I take pleasure in infirmities, in reproaches, in needs, in persecutions, in distresses, for Christ's sake. For when I am weak, then I am strong" (2 Corinthians 12:9-10).

Paul learned that his cracks were not liabilities; they were opportunities. His weaknesses were not obstacles to God's power; they were conduits for it. When he was weak, he was actually strong, because Christ's power had room to work.

### **The Danger of Forgetting**

If the danger of clay is that we might underestimate what God can do through us, the danger of treasure is that we might overestimate our own importance. Both extremes must be avoided.

Some believers look at their clay and despair. They see their limitations, their failures, their ordinariness, and they conclude that God cannot use them. They think that because they are not

golden vessels, they have nothing to offer. They hide their light, convinced that no one would want to see it anyway.

Others look at the treasure and become proud. They begin to think that the light is their own. They start to believe that their gifts, their insights, their achievements are products of their own greatness. They forget that they are merely clay, that the treasure is borrowed, that the power is not their own.

Both errors are deadly. The first robs the world of light. The second robs God of glory. The healthy Christian life holds both truths in tension: I am clay, but I carry treasure. I am ordinary, but I contain the extraordinary. I am weak, but His power is made perfect in my weakness.

### **The Care of the Vessel**

If we are clay pots carrying precious treasure, how should we treat ourselves? How should we care for the vessels that contain the light?

First, we should not neglect the vessel. Some Christians, in their zeal for the spiritual, neglect the physical. They do not take care of their bodies. They do not get enough rest. They do not attend to their emotional health. They treat the vessel as unimportant.

But the vessel matters because it contains the treasure. A cracked pot can still be used, but a shattered pot cannot. We have a responsibility to care for ourselves, body, mind, and soul so that we can continue to carry the light.

Second, we should not worship the vessel. Other Christians go to the opposite extreme. They become obsessed with the container. They focus on appearance, on performance, on image. They polish the outside while neglecting the inside. They become like the whitewashed tombs Jesus described beautiful on the outside but full of death on the inside.

The vessel matters, but only because of what it contains. We care for ourselves not because we are valuable in ourselves but because we carry something infinitely valuable. We are stewards of these bodies, these minds, these lives. And good stewards take care of what has been entrusted to them.

Third, we should expect the vessel to be tested. Clay pots in the ancient world were used for all kinds of purposes. They carried water. They stored grain. They held oil. And in all these uses, they were bumped, moved, emptied, refilled. They were not displayed in museums; they were used in daily life.

We should expect the same. If we are carrying the light of Christ, we will be placed in situations that test our vessel. We will be bumped by difficult circumstances. We will be emptied by

seasons of trial. We will be refilled by times of refreshing. This is normal. This is part of being a useful vessel.

### **The Glory of the Ordinary**

There is something deeply encouraging about the metaphor of earthen vessels. It means that God does not require us to be extraordinary to be used by Him. He does not need us to be brilliant, talented, or impressive. He just needs us to be available—ordinary clay pots willing to carry His extraordinary treasure.

Think through the people God has used throughout history. Moses stuttered. David was the youngest, least impressive son. Peter was impulsive and unreliable. Paul had a thorn in his flesh. The list goes on and on. God's pattern is to choose the weak, the foolish, the ordinary, so that His power is unmistakable.

"For you see your calling, brethren, that not many wise according to the flesh, not many mighty, not many noble, are called. But God has chosen the foolish things of the world to put to shame the wise, and God has chosen the weak things of the world to put to shame the things which are mighty; and the base things of the world and the things which are despised God has chosen, and the things which are not, to bring to nothing the things that are, that no flesh should glory in His presence" (1 Corinthians 1:26-29).

This is who we are: the foolish, the weak, the base, the despised. And this is what we carry: the wisdom, power, and glory of God. The combination is explosive. The paradox is glorious.

### **The Flame That Transforms**

There is one more thing we must understand about the flame and the vessel. The flame does not just shine through the vessel; it also transforms it.

When you place a clay pot in a fire, something happens. The fire that illuminates also hardens. The heat that provides light also strengthens. The flame that shines through also purifies.

This is what the presence of God does within us. The light of Christ does not just shine out from us; it works in us. It exposes impurities. It burns away dross. It strengthens what is weak. It transforms us from one degree of glory to another.

**Paul writes about this process:**

"But we all, with unveiled face, beholding as in a mirror the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from glory to glory, just as by the Spirit of the Lord" (2 Corinthians 3:18).

The light within us is not static. It is active. It is working. It is transforming us into the very image of the One whose light we carry. The flame that shines through us is also refining us. The treasure within us is also changing us.

This is the journey of a lifetime. We are being made into what we carry. We are becoming the light we contain. The vessel is slowly, gradually, being transformed to match the treasure.

### **Clay and Glory**

You are clay. Never forget that. You are ordinary. You are fragile. You are common. You crack under pressure. You chip when bumped. You are, in yourself, unremarkable.

But you carry glory. Never forget that either. You contain the light of the knowledge of God's glory. The treasure of Christ's presence dwells within you. The flame of the Spirit burns in your heart.

Clay and glory. Fragility and fire. Ordinariness and the extraordinary. This is who you are. This is what you carry. And this combination, this impossible, paradoxical combination is exactly what God intends.

Let the clay be clay. Let it be honest about its limitations. Let it acknowledge its cracks. Let it stop pretending to be something it is not.

And let the glory be glory. Let it shine. Let it escape through the cracks. Let it illuminate the darkness. Let it transform the vessel from the inside out.

You are clay carrying glory. And that is more than enough.

### **Prayer for the Journey**

Lord, I thank You that You have chosen to place Your precious treasure in earthen vessels like me. I thank You that You do not require me to be golden or impressive, only available and willing.

Father, I confess that I have sometimes despaired over my clay. I have looked at my limitations and concluded that You cannot use me. Forgive me for limiting Your power by my assumptions. Help me to see that Your strength is made perfect in my weakness.

I also confess that I have sometimes taken credit for Your treasure. I have acted as if the light were my own. Forgive me for my pride. Keep me humble. Help me always to remember that any good in me is from You.

Use my cracks to let Your light out. Use my weaknesses to display Your strength. Use my clay to carry Your glory. Transform me, day by day, into the image of the One whose light I carry.

I am Yours. Do with me as You will. In Jesus' name, Amen.



# CHAPTER FOUR

## When Darkness Intrudes

"The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness did not comprehend it." — John 1:5 (NKJV)

There is a question that every believer eventually asks, usually in the middle of the night when sleep will not come and the weight of the world presses down: If I carry the light within me, why is my life so dark sometimes?

It is an honest question. It deserves an honest answer. Because the reality is that darkness intrudes. It intrudes into our circumstances, into our emotions, into our relationships, into our very souls. And when it does, we wonder what has gone wrong. We question whether the light is really there. We doubt whether we truly carry what we thought we carried.

John's gospel opens with a profound statement about the relationship between light and darkness: "The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness did not comprehend it." The word comprehend can also be translated overcome or overpower. The darkness did not overcome the light. The darkness could not extinguish it. The darkness, for all its power, was powerless against the light.

But notice: the light shines in the darkness. Not in a place with no darkness. Not in a realm where darkness has been eliminated. In the darkness. The light operates in the very place where darkness exists. It does its work in the context of opposition.

This is crucial for us to understand. The presence of darkness does not mean the absence of light. The two coexist in this fallen world. And they will coexist until the day when the light fully and finally triumphs.

## The Many Faces of Darkness

Darkness wears many faces. It is not a single enemy but a multifaceted opposition that attacks from many angles.

There is the darkness of circumstances. Financial pressure that keeps you awake at night. Health issues that drain your strength and hope. Family problems that seem to have no solution. Career setbacks that leave you wondering about your future. These are real darknesses, and they press in on every side.

There is the darkness of emotions. Depression that colors everything gray. Anxiety that makes the future seem threatening. Grief that hollows out your chest and leaves you empty. Loneliness

that persists even in a crowd. These emotional darknesses are not imaginary; they are as real as physical pain.

There is the darkness of relationships. Conflict with a spouse that leaves you feeling disconnected. Betrayal by a friend that makes trust difficult. Rejection by family that cuts to the core. Criticism from others that chips away at your confidence. Relationships can be sources of great light, but they can also be sources of deep darkness.

There is the darkness of spiritual attack. The enemy of our souls is real, and he actively works to dim the light within us. He whispers lies about God's goodness. He accuses us of sins already forgiven. He tempts us to doubt what we know to be true. He sows confusion and despair. This darkness is not merely psychological; it is demonic.

There is the darkness of our own flesh. Old habits die hard. Sin patterns reassert themselves. The remnants of our former way of life still exert pull. We find ourselves doing what we do not want to do and not doing what we want to do. The darkness within wars against the light within.

All of these darknesses are real. All of them intrude into our lives. And all of them raise the question: Where is the light?

### **The Promise of Presence**

When darkness intrudes, the first thing we must remember is that we are not alone in it. The light within us is not a distant light; it is a present light. Christ, who is the light, dwells within us by His Spirit. And He has promised never to leave us or forsake us.

### **The psalmist understood this:**

"Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for You are with me; Your rod and Your staff, they comfort me" (Psalm 23:4).

Notice: the valley is real. The shadow of death is present. The psalmist does not deny the darkness. He does not pretend that everything is fine. But in the midst of the darkness, he affirms the presence: "You are with me."

This is the promise we must cling to when darkness intrudes. The light is not somewhere else, waiting for the darkness to pass before it returns. The light is within us, right now, in this very moment of darkness. It may feel hidden. It may seem dim. But it is there.

### **The Purpose of Darkness**

This is a difficult question, but we must ask it: Does darkness serve any purpose in the life of a believer? Is there any reason God allows it to intrude?

**The Scriptures suggest that there is.**

Darkness reveals what is in us. When everything is going well, it is easy to think we are strong. It is easy to believe we have great faith. But when darkness comes, we see what is really there. The trials reveal the true state of our hearts. They expose areas of weakness we did not know existed. They show us where we need to grow.

**Peter writes about this:**

"In this you greatly rejoice, though now for a little while, if need be, you have been grieved by various trials, that the genuineness of your faith, being much more precious than gold that perishes, though it is tested by fire, may be found to praise, honor, and glory at the revelation of Jesus Christ" (1 Peter 1:6-7).

The trials test the genuineness of our faith. They reveal whether our faith is real or merely a convenient sentiment. They show us—and others—what we are truly made of.

Darkness deepens our dependence on God. When life is easy, we tend to rely on ourselves. We think we can handle things. We forget our need for God. But when darkness comes, we are driven to our knees. We cry out for help. We cling to Him in ways we never would otherwise.

**Paul experienced this:**

"We were burdened beyond measure, above strength, so that we despaired even of life. Yes, we had the sentence of death in ourselves, that we should not trust in ourselves but in God who raises the dead" (2 Corinthians 1:8-9).

The pressure was so intense that Paul despaired of life itself. But that pressure served a purpose: it taught him not to trust in himself but in God. The darkness drove him to deeper dependence.

Darkness prepares us for greater usefulness. Those who have suffered are uniquely equipped to comfort others who suffer. Those who have walked through darkness carry light for others who are just entering it. Our trials become training grounds for ministry.

**Paul again:**

"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of mercies and God of all comfort, who comforts us in all our tribulation, that we may be able to comfort those who are in any trouble, with the comfort with which we ourselves are comforted by God" (2 Corinthians 1:3-4).

We are comforted in our tribulation so that we can comfort others. The darkness we experience becomes the context for the light we offer.

### **The Response to Darkness**

Given that darkness will intrude, how should we respond when it comes?

First, we should not be surprised. Jesus told us it would be this way:

"In the world you will have tribulation; but be of good cheer, I have overcome the world" (John 16:33).

He did not say we might have tribulation. He said we will have it. It is normal. It is expected. When darkness comes, we should not conclude that something has gone wrong. We should recognize that we are experiencing what Jesus promised.

Second, we should not lose heart. Paul writes:

"Therefore we do not lose heart. Even though our outward man is perishing, yet the inward man is being renewed day by day. For our light affliction, which is but for a moment, is working for us a far more exceeding and eternal weight of glory" (2 Corinthians 4:16-17).

Notice the perspective. Paul calls his afflictions "light" and "momentary" even though we know from his writings that he endured beatings, imprisonment, shipwreck, and countless other hardships. How could he describe such things as light? Because he was comparing them to the eternal weight of glory. His perspective was shaped by eternity.

Third, we should look to Jesus. The author of Hebrews gives us the ultimate example:

"Looking unto Jesus, the author and finisher of our faith, who for the joy that was set before Him endured the cross, despising the shame, and has sat down at the right hand of the throne of God" (Hebrews 12:2).

Jesus endured the ultimate darkness—the cross, separation from the Father, the weight of the world's sin—by looking beyond it to the joy set before Him. He trusted that the darkness would not have the final word. He believed that light would dawn again.

### **The Victory of Light**

The final word on darkness is this: it does not win.

John's gospel declares it: "The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness did not comprehend it." The darkness tried. It threw everything it had against the light. But it could not overcome. It could not extinguish. It could not comprehend.

### **Paul celebrates this victory:**

"Who shall separate us from the love of Christ? Shall tribulation, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or peril, or sword? As it is written: 'For Your sake we are killed all day long; we are accounted as sheep for the slaughter.' Yet in all these things we are more than conquerors through Him who loved us" (Romans 8:35-37).

**NOTICE:** in all these things we are more than conquerors. Not after they are over. Not when we escape them. In them. In the very midst of tribulation, distress, persecution, we are already victorious. The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness cannot overcome it.

This is our confidence. This is our hope. The darkness will intrude. It will press in from every side. It will threaten to overwhelm. But it will not succeed. The light within us is stronger than any darkness without.

### **When You Cannot Feel the Light**

There is one more thing we must address. Sometimes, when darkness intrudes, we cannot feel the light. The emotions that once accompanied our faith seem absent. The sense of God's presence that once comforted us is gone. We feel dry, empty, abandoned.

## **What then?**

We must remember that faith is not feeling. The presence of the light does not depend on our perception of it. The sun continues to shine even when clouds hide it from view. The fire continues to burn even when we cannot feel its heat. The light within you is still there, even when you cannot sense it.

## **The psalmist knew this experience:**

"My God, my God, why have You forsaken me? Why are You so far from helping me, and from the words of my groaning? O My God, I cry in the daytime, but You do not hear; and in the night season, and am not silent" (Psalm 22:1-2).

These words, later quoted by Jesus on the cross, express the agony of feeling abandoned by God. And yet, even in this cry of dereliction, there is faith. He still calls God my God. He still cries out. He still believes, even when he cannot feel.

When you cannot feel the light, hold on to what you know. You know the promises of God. You know the character of God. You know the faithfulness of God in the past. Hold on to what you know, even when you cannot feel what you want to feel. The light is still there. The darkness has not overcome it.

## **The Morning Always Comes**

The psalmist also wrote:

"Weeping may endure for a night, but joy comes in the morning" (Psalm 30:5).

The night is real. The weeping is real. But the night does not last forever. The morning always comes. Joy always returns. The light always dawns again.

This is not wishful thinking. This is the pattern of Scripture. This is the testimony of every saint who has walked through darkness. The night may be long, but it is not eternal. The darkness may be deep, but it is not bottomless. The morning comes.

And one morning, the final morning, there will be no more night.

"There shall be no night there: They need no lamp nor light of the sun, for the Lord God gives them light. And they shall reign forever and ever" (Revelation 22:5).

Until that morning, we shine in the darkness. We carry the light through the night. We bear witness that the darkness has not won and will not win. The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness has not overcome it.

### **Prayer for the Journey**

Lord of light, I thank You that You are the light that shines in the darkness. I thank You that the darkness has not overcome You and cannot overcome those who are in You.

Father, I am honest with You about the darkness I am facing. You see it. You know it. You are not surprised by it. I bring it to You now and ask for Your presence in the midst of it.

When I cannot feel Your light, help me to hold on to what I know. When the night seems long, give me patience to wait for the morning. When I am tempted to despair, fill me with hope that does not disappoint.

Use this darkness for Your purposes. Reveal what needs to be revealed. Deepen my dependence on You. Prepare me for greater usefulness. And through it all, let Your light shine in me and through me.

I trust that the morning will come. Until then, I will hold onto You. In Jesus' name, Amen.

# CHAPTER FIVE

## Fuel for the Journey

"But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, longsuffering, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control. Against such there is no law." — Galatians 5:22-23 (NKJV)

Every light needs fuel. A candle consumes wax. An oil lamp drinks oil. A fire devours wood. Without fuel, the brightest flame sputters, flickers, and dies. The light may be genuine, but without sustenance, it cannot endure.

The light within you is no different. The spark of divine life that has been kindled in your heart requires fuel to keep burning. Not because the light is weak, but because you live in a fallen world. Not because the Spirit is insufficient, but because you are still in the flesh. Not because God abandons His work, but because He has designed you to participate in your own maintenance.

The fuel for your journey is the fruit of the Spirit.

### The Source of the Fuel

Before we examine the fruit itself, we must understand where it comes from. Paul is clear: this is the fruit of the Spirit. It is not the fruit of human effort. It is not the product of self-discipline. It is not the result of trying harder. It is the natural outflow of a life filled with and led by the Holy Spirit.

Jesus used the imagery of a vine and branches to convey this truth:

"I am the vine, you are the branches. He who abides in Me, and I in him, bears much fruit; for without Me you can do nothing" (John 15:5).

The branch does not struggle to produce fruit. It does not strain or strive. It simply abides in the vine, drawing nourishment from the root, and fruit appears naturally in its season. The branch's job is not production but connection. Stay connected, and fruit will come.

This is profoundly liberating. It means that the fruit of the Spirit is not a checklist to achieve but a reality to receive. It is not about working harder but about abiding deeper. It is not about manufacturing character but about cultivating connection.



And yet, we have a role to play. Abiding is not passive. It requires intention. It requires attention. It requires choices that keep us connected to the Vine. The fuel is provided by the Spirit, but we must position ourselves to receive it.

## **The Ninefold Flame**

Paul lists nine characteristics that together form the fruit of the Spirit. Think of them not as nine separate fruits but as nine facets of a single diamond, nine colors in a single beam of light, nine flames that together make one fire.

Love. This is the first and greatest. Not the sentimental affection the world calls love, but agape, the self-sacrificing, unconditional love that seeks the highest good of others regardless of their response. This is the love God has for us and the love He pours into our hearts by the Holy Spirit. It is the fuel that makes all other fruit possible.

Joy. Not happiness, which depends on circumstances, but joy, which depends on relationship. The joy of the Lord is our strength. It is the deep settled confidence that God is good, that He is in control, and that our future is secure. This joy can coexist with sorrow, can persist through pain, can shine in the darkest night.

Peace. Not the absence of conflict but the presence of wholeness. Shalom—the deep peace that passes understanding, that guards our hearts and minds in Christ Jesus. This peace is not the product of favorable circumstances but of unwavering trust. It is the calm in the storm, the stillness in the chaos, the quiet in the noise.

Longsuffering. Patience. The ability to endure difficult people and trying circumstances without snapping. This is the fuel that keeps us going when the journey is long and the end is not in sight. It is the grace that allows us to wait without complaining, to suffer without souring, to persevere without giving up.

Kindness. Goodness in action toward others. The gentle word, the helping hand, the thoughtful gesture. Kindness is love with its sleeves rolled up, compassion with feet and hands. It is the warmth that makes the light approachable, the tenderness that makes the flame inviting.

Goodness. Moral excellence, integrity, virtue. This is the character that results from a life lived in alignment with God's ways. It is not merely the absence of evil but the presence of positive good. It is the light that not only exposes darkness but also illuminates beauty.

Faithfulness. Reliability, trustworthiness, loyalty. The person who bears this fruit keeps their promises, fulfills their commitments, and remains steadfast even when it costs something. Faithfulness is the fuel that sustains long-term relationships, long-term service, long-term obedience.

Gentleness. Meekness, not weakness. Power under control. The gentle person does not need to assert themselves because they know who they are. They do not need to dominate because they are secure. They handle others with care because they have been handled with care by God.

Self-control. Mastery over one's own impulses and desires. The ability to say no to the flesh and yes to the Spirit. Self-control is the guard that protects all the other fruit, the gate that keeps the flame within its proper bounds.

### **Love: The Primary Fuel**

Of all the facets of the fruit, love is primary. Paul makes this clear in 1 Corinthians 13:

"Though I speak with the tongues of men and of angels, but have not love, I have become sounding brass or a clanging cymbal. And though I have the gift of prophecy, and understand all mysteries and all knowledge, and though I have all faith, so that I could remove mountains, but have not love, I am nothing" (1 Corinthians 13:1-2).

Without love, the most impressive gifts are worthless. Without love, the most heroic sacrifices are empty. Without love, the brightest light is just noise.

Love is the fuel that makes all other fruit possible. Joy without love becomes mere optimism. Peace without love becomes detachment. Longsuffering without love becomes resentment. Kindness without love becomes manipulation. Goodness without love becomes self-righteousness. Faithfulness without love becomes obligation. Gentleness without love becomes weakness. Self-control without love becomes repression.

But when love fuels the flame, everything changes. Joy becomes deep and authentic. Peace becomes resilient and contagious. Longsuffering becomes patient and hopeful. Kindness becomes genuine and costly. Goodness becomes attractive and compelling. Faithfulness becomes joyful and sustainable. Gentleness becomes powerful and disarming. Self-control becomes freeing and life-giving.

### **The Function of the Fruit**

Why does the Spirit produce this fruit in our lives? What purpose does it serve?

The fruit fuels our own flame. Love, joy, peace—these are not just for others; they are for us. They sustain us in the journey. They keep us going when the road is hard. They replenish what

the trials of life deplete. A loveless Christian cannot shine. A joyless Christian cannot attract. A peaceless Christian cannot calm the storms around them.

The fruit makes the light attractive. People are drawn to love. They are comforted by joy. They are calmed by peace. They are encouraged by patience. They are warmed by kindness. They are inspired by goodness. They are reassured by faithfulness. They are disarmed by gentleness. They are impressed by self-control. When these qualities shine through us, the light becomes not just visible but desirable.

### **The fruit authenticates the message. Jesus said:**

"By this all will know that you are My disciples, if you have love for one another" (John 13:35).

Our love authenticates our claim to follow the One who is love. Our joy validates our message of good news. Our peace demonstrates the reality of the reconciliation we proclaim. The fruit of the Spirit is the evidence that the Spirit is truly within us.

The fruit serves others. Love meets needs. Kindness blesses. Goodness builds up. Faithfulness keeps promises. Gentleness handles fragile hearts with care. The fruit of the Spirit is not just for our benefit; it is for the benefit of everyone around us. It is the fuel that powers our service, the energy that drives our ministry.

### **Cultivating the Connection**

If the fruit comes from abiding in the Vine, then our primary task is to cultivate that connection. How do we do that?

Through prayer. Prayer is the lifeline of the soul. It is how we communicate with the Vine, how we draw nourishment from the Root, how we stay connected to the Source. In prayer, we confess our dependence. In prayer, we express our needs. In prayer, we receive the grace we need to bear fruit.

Through the Word. Scripture is the nutrient-rich soil in which our roots grow. The words of Christ dwell in us richly as we read, study, and meditate on the Bible. These words shape our thinking, guide our choices, and feed our spirits. A Bible-starved Christian cannot bear much fruit.

Through community. We were not designed to abide alone. The Vine has many branches, and we need each other. In community, we receive encouragement when we are weary. In community, we receive correction when we wander. In community, we receive examples that inspire us to greater fruitfulness.

Through obedience. Jesus said:

"If you keep My commandments, you will abide in My love, just as I have kept My Father's commandments and abide in His love" (John 15:10).

Obedience deepens connection. When we do what He says, we remain in the flow of His life. Disobedience, on the other hand, clogs the channels. It hinders the flow of sap from the Vine to the branch.

Through suffering. Suffering, though painful, can deepen our abiding. When circumstances drive us to our knees, we cling to the Vine more tightly. When we have nowhere else to go, we go to Him. The trials that threaten to separate us from the Vine often end up attaching us more firmly.

### **When the Fruit Seems Scarce**

There will be seasons when the fruit seems scarce. When love feels cold. When joy seems distant. When peace is elusive. When patience runs thin. When kindness feels forced. When goodness seems beyond reach. When faithfulness falters. When gentleness gives way to harshness. When self-control fails.

### **What then?**

First, do not panic. Seasons of spiritual dryness are normal. Even the most fruitful branches experience times when the sap seems to flow less freely. The psalmist knew this:

"As the deer pants for the water brooks, so pants my soul for You, O God. My soul thirsts for God, for the living God" (Psalm 42:1-2).

The panting and thirsting are themselves signs of life. Dead things do not thirst. Only living things long for what they lack.

Second, examine the connection. Is something hindering your abiding? Unconfessed sin? Neglected disciplines? Broken relationships? Busyness that crowds out time with the Vine? Ask the Spirit to show you any blockages that need to be removed.

Third, return to the basics. Go back to prayer. Go back to the Word. Go back to community. Go back to the simple practices that have sustained believers for centuries. Sometimes the path to fruitfulness is simply returning to the fundamentals.

Fourth, wait. Fruit takes time to grow. You cannot rush the seasons of the spirit. The farmer waits patiently for the precious fruit of the earth. You must wait patiently for the Spirit's work in your life.

"Be patient, brethren, until the coming of the Lord. See how the farmer waits for the precious fruit of the earth, waiting patiently for it until it receives the early and latter rain" (James 5:7).

### **The Purpose of Abundance**

Why does the Spirit want to produce abundant fruit in your life? Why does He pour this fuel into your vessel?

#### **For your joy. Jesus said:**

"These things I have spoken to you, that My joy may remain in you, and that your joy may be full" (John 15:11).

The fruit is for your joy. A life marked by love, joy, peace—this is a joyful life. The Spirit's fruit is not a burden but a blessing. It is not weight to carry but wings to fly.

#### **For God's glory. Jesus also said:**

"By this My Father is glorified, that you bear much fruit; so you will be My disciples" (John 15:8).

When you bear fruit, God is glorified. Your love displays His love. Your joy reflects His joy. Your peace testifies to His peace. The fruit in your life points beyond you to the Vine who produced it.

For the world's good. The world is hungry for what you carry. People are starving for love, thirsting for joy, desperate for peace. When you bear fruit, you feed the hungry. You become the answer to someone's prayer. You are the vessel through which God meets the needs of a hurting world.

## **Fuel for the Long Haul**

The Christian life is a marathon, not a sprint. It requires fuel that will last for the long haul. The fruit of the Spirit is that fuel.

Love that does not run out. Joy that does not depend on circumstances. Peace that passes understanding. Patience that endures through decades. Kindness that never grows weary. Goodness that remains consistent. Faithfulness that lasts a lifetime. Gentleness that handles even the most fragile situations. Self-control that governs every impulse.

This is what the Spirit produces. This is the fuel He provides. This is what you need for the journey ahead.

Draw deeply from the Vine. Stay connected to the Source. Let the sap of the Spirit flow through you. And you will bear fruit, fruit that remains, fruit that fuels, fruit that shines.

## **Prayer for the Journey**

Vinekeeper and Vine, I thank You that You are the source of all fruitfulness. I thank You that You do not leave me to produce character on my own but pour Your Spirit into me to bear fruit that remains.

Lord, I confess that I have sometimes tried to manufacture fruit in my own strength. I have strived for love, strained for joy, struggled for peace. Forgive me for my self-reliance. Teach me to abide more deeply.

Examine my connection to You. Show me anything that hinders the flow of Your life through me. Remove the blockages. Clear the channels. Let Your sap flow freely.

I receive the fuel You provide. I welcome the fruit You produce. Let love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control mark my life more and more.

For my joy, for Your glory, and for the world's good. In Jesus' name, Amen.

# CHAPTER SIX

## Reflections of Glory

"And we all, with unveiled face, beholding as in a mirror the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from glory to glory, just as by the Spirit of the Lord." — 2 Corinthians 3:18 (NKJV)

There is a story in the Old Testament that holds a key to understanding the Christian life. It is the story of Moses coming down from Mount Sinai after being in the presence of God. The Scripture says:

"So it was, when Moses came down from Mount Sinai (and the two tablets of the Testimony were in Moses' hand when he came down from the mountain), that Moses did not know that the skin of his face shone while he talked with Him" (Exodus 34:29).

Moses had been in the presence of glory, and that glory rubbed off on him. His face shone with a reflected radiance. He did not generate the light; he merely carried it. He did not produce the glory; he simply absorbed it through proximity.

This is the heart of what it means to be a reflection of glory. We do not originate light; we reflect it. We do not generate glory; we absorb it through time spent in the presence of the Glorious One. And as we reflect His glory, something remarkable happens: we are transformed into that very image.

### The Mirror and the Image

Paul uses a fascinating combination of metaphors in 2 Corinthians 3:18. He speaks of beholding glory as in a mirror. In the ancient world, mirrors were not made of glass as they are today. They were made of polished metal, bronze or silver. They provided a reflection, but it was never perfect. It was always somewhat dim, somewhat distorted.

Yet Paul says we behold the glory of the Lord in such a mirror. We see Him, but not directly. We see Him reflected. And as we behold Him, we are transformed into the same image.

The process is progressive: from glory to glory. It does not happen all at once. It is a journey, not a destination. Each stage of beholding leads to a stage of becoming. Each glimpse of glory produces a measure of transformation. And the transformation continues as long as the beholding continues.

The agent of this transformation is the Spirit: just as by the Spirit of the Lord. We cannot transform ourselves. We cannot manufacture Christlikeness through effort. It is the Spirit's work, accomplished as we behold the glory of the Lord.

### **What We Behold, We Become**

There is a principle at work here that extends beyond the spiritual realm. It is a principle of human nature: what we behold, we become.

If you spend your days beholding the glory of wealth scrolling through images of luxury, dreaming of possessions, envying the rich, you will become increasingly consumed with materialism. Your heart will conform to the image of what you worship.

If you spend your days beholding the glory of human approval—monitoring your social media likes, craving recognition, fearing rejection—you will become increasingly shaped by the opinions of others. Your identity will conform to the expectations of your audience.

If you spend your days beholding the glory of entertainment—binge-watching shows, scrolling through videos, escaping into virtual worlds—you will become increasingly detached from reality. Your mind will conform to the patterns of the culture.

But if you spend your days beholding the glory of the Lord—gazing at His beauty in Scripture, contemplating His character in prayer, worshiping His majesty in song—you will become increasingly like Him. Your heart will conform to His heart. Your mind will take on His mind. Your life will reflect His life.

This is not magic. It is the natural result of focus. What captures your attention shapes your affections. What shapes your affections determines your actions. What determines your actions forms your character. What forms your character becomes your destiny.

### **The Unveiled Face**

Paul mentions another crucial element: with unveiled face. He is drawing on the Moses story again. When Moses came down from the mountain, his face shone with glory. But over time, that glory began to fade. And Moses began to veil his face so that the Israelites would not see the glory fading.

Paul interprets this veil differently in the new covenant:

"But their minds were blinded. For until this day the same veil remains unlifted in the reading of the Old Testament, because the veil is taken away in Christ. But even to this day, when Moses is



read, a veil lies on their heart. Nevertheless when one turns to the Lord, the veil is taken away" (2 Corinthians 3:14-16).

The veil, in Paul's understanding, is not on Moses' face but on the hearts of those who do not see Christ in the Scriptures. It is a veil of blindness, of hardness, of unbelief. It prevents them from seeing the glory that is revealed in Christ.

But for those who turn to the Lord, the veil is removed. We see with unveiled faces. We behold without hindrance. We gaze directly upon the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ.

This is our privilege and our responsibility. The veil is gone. The way is open. We can behold the glory of the Lord without anything standing between. The question is whether we will take advantage of this access.

### **Where Glory Is Beheld**

Where do we behold the glory of the Lord? How do we gaze upon His beauty?

In Scripture. The primary place where we encounter the glory of God is in His Word. Here, the character of God is revealed. Here, the works of God are recorded. Here, the promises of God are declared. Here, the face of Jesus is seen on every page.

### **The psalmist wrote:**

"Open my eyes, that I may see wondrous things from Your law" (Psalm 119:18).

The wonders are there. The glory is present. But we need our eyes opened to see it. We need the Spirit to illuminate the Word and reveal the glory within.

In prayer. Prayer is not just asking for things; it is beholding the One to whom we pray. In prayer, we gaze upon His majesty. In prayer, we contemplate His character. In prayer, we soak in His presence. The glory that fills the heavens is accessible in the secret place.

In worship. When we gather with God's people and lift our voices in praise, something happens. The glory descends. The presence is manifested. We behold Him together in ways we cannot behold Him alone. Corporate worship is a school of beholding.

In creation. The heavens declare the glory of God. The skies proclaim the work of His hands. Every sunrise is a sermon. Every star is a Scripture. Every mountain is a monument to His majesty. Creation itself is a mirror reflecting the glory of the Creator.

In the face of others. There is a mysterious way in which we behold God's glory in His people. When we see love in action, we see His love. When we witness forgiveness, we see His forgiveness. When we encounter kindness, we see His kindness. The body of Christ is a reflection of the Head.

### **The Transforming Gaze**

As we behold, we are transformed. But how does this transformation happen?

Through conviction. When we behold the holiness of God, we see our own unholiness. When we gaze upon His purity, we recognize our impurity. The light exposes the darkness. The glory reveals the flaws. This conviction is not meant to discourage us but to drive us to the One who can cleanse and change us.

### **Isaiah experienced this when he beheld the Lord:**

"Woe is me, for I am undone! Because I am a man of unclean lips, and I dwell in the midst of a people of unclean lips; for my eyes have seen the King, the Lord of hosts" (Isaiah 6:5).

The vision of glory produced conviction. But that conviction led to cleansing. The seraphim touched his lips with a live coal from the altar, and his iniquity was taken away.

Through attraction. We become like what we love. When we behold the beauty of Christ, we grow in love for Him. And as love grows, likeness follows. We naturally imitate those we admire. We unconsciously absorb the characteristics of those we adore.

Through assimilation. This is the mystery of spiritual formation: as we spend time in the presence of glory, that glory rubs off on us. We do not try to become like Christ; we simply spend time with Him, and likeness happens. It is the natural result of relationship.

### **The Glory That Grows**

Notice that Paul says we are transformed from glory to glory. This implies progression. The glory increases. The reflection becomes clearer. The likeness becomes more pronounced.

This is encouraging because it means we do not have to arrive all at once. Transformation is a process. Today, you may reflect a little glory. Tomorrow, a little more. Next year, more still. As you continue beholding, you continue becoming.

It is also challenging because it means there is always more. No matter how much you have grown, there is further to go. No matter how clearly you reflect His image, there is greater clarity to be attained. The journey from glory to glory never ends in this life.

### **Paul expressed this holy dissatisfaction:**

"Not that I have already attained, or am already perfected; but I press on, that I may lay hold of that for which Christ Jesus has also laid hold of me" (Philippians 3:12).

He had seen glory, but he wanted more. He had been transformed, but he pressed on. The journey from glory to glory is a journey of holy hunger, of divine discontent, of eternal aspiration.

### **The Corporate Reflection**

While the transformation is personal, it is not individualistic. Paul uses the plural we all. The whole community of believers is beholding and being transformed together.

This is important because we need each other in the process of becoming. We see aspects of Christ in others that we cannot see on our own. We are encouraged by their growth. We are challenged by their examples. We are held accountable by their presence.

The body of Christ together reflects the glory of Christ in ways no individual can. Each member reflects a different facet. Together, we display the full spectrum. The corporate reflection is richer, deeper, and more complete than any individual reflection could be.

### **Practical Pathways to Beholding**

How do we make beholding a regular part of our lives? How do we ensure that we are gazing upon glory consistently?

Establish a daily rhythm. Set aside time each day to behold the Lord in Scripture and prayer. This is not a legalistic requirement but a life-giving practice. The daily rhythm keeps the glory before your eyes.

Create space for stillness. Beholding requires unhurried attention. You cannot gaze at glory while rushing through a checklist. Create space in your schedule for stillness, for quiet, for undivided attention to the Lord.

Use Scripture as a lens. When you read the Bible, look for Christ. Ask the Spirit to show you the glory of the Lord in every passage. The whole Scriptures testify of Him. Train your eyes to see Him on every page.

Practice the presence. Throughout your day, turn your heart toward the Lord. Lift brief prayers. Whisper praises. Recall His promises. The practice of His presence keeps you beholding even in the midst of activity.

Gather with God's people. Do not neglect corporate worship and fellowship. In the assembly of the saints, you behold glory in ways you cannot alone. The body reflects the Head. Gather regularly to see His glory in His people.

### **The Ultimate Reflection**

There is coming a day when we will behold Him face to face. Then the partial will give way to the perfect. Then the dim reflection will give way to direct sight. Then we will be fully transformed, for we will see Him as He is.

#### **John writes:**

"Beloved, now we are children of God; and it has not yet been revealed what we shall be, but we know that when He is revealed, we shall be like Him, for we shall see Him as He is" (1 John 3:2).

The ultimate transformation awaits the ultimate beholding. When we see Him as He is, we will become like Him. The journey from glory to glory will reach its destination. The reflection will become reality.

Until that day, we behold. We gaze. We reflect. We are transformed. From glory to glory, by the Spirit of the Lord.

### **Prayer for the Journey**

Lord of glory, I thank You that You have revealed Yourself in the face of Jesus Christ. I thank You that the veil is removed and I can behold Your glory with unveiled face.

Father, I confess that I have beheld many other glories. I have gazed at wealth, approval, entertainment, and allowed them to shape me. Forgive me. Redirect my gaze. Capture my attention with Your beauty.

Open my eyes to see wondrous things in Your Word. Still my heart to behold You in prayer. Lift my voice to worship You with Your people. Open my eyes to see Your glory in creation and in Your children.

As I behold, transform me. From glory to glory, make me like the One I love. Let Your Spirit do His work in me, conforming me to the image of Christ.

I long for the day when I will see You face to face. Until then, I will keep beholding. In Jesus' name, Amen.

# CHAPTER SEVEN

## Walking in the Light

"If we say that we have fellowship with Him, and walk in darkness, we lie and do not practice the truth. But if we walk in the light as He is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus Christ His Son cleanses us from all sin." — 1 John 1:6-7 (NKJV)

There is a difference between carrying light and walking in it. You can have the light within and still walk in darkness. You can possess the treasure and still live in the shadows. The presence of light does not guarantee the practice of light.

John addresses this danger directly. He has been speaking about the glorious reality of fellowship with God, a fellowship made possible by the incarnation of the Word of life. But then he introduces a warning: it is possible to claim this fellowship while living in a way that contradicts it.

"If we say that we have fellowship with Him, and walk in darkness, we lie and do not practice the truth."

The claim and the conduct must match. The profession and the practice must align. The light within must become light in the walk.

### Walking as a Metaphor

The Bible uses the metaphor of walking to describe the overall direction and character of a person's life. Walking is not a single act but a continuous pattern. It is not a moment but a movement. It is not an isolated decision but an ongoing direction.

When Scripture speaks of walking in darkness, it refers to a life characterized by darkness—a pattern of living that contradicts God's ways, that ignores God's commands, that rejects God's light. This is not about occasional stumbles but about habitual direction. It is not about falling into sin but about living in sin.

When Scripture speaks of walking in the light, it refers to a life characterized by light—a pattern of living that aligns with God's character, that follows God's commands, that embraces God's truth. This is not about perfection but about direction. It is not about never stumbling but about always getting back up and heading toward the light.

### The Claim That Condemns

John's warning is sharp: "If we say that we have fellowship with Him, and walk in darkness, we lie."

The claim of fellowship without the reality of obedience is a lie. It is self-deception at best and deliberate deception at worst. It is claiming a relationship that does not exist, professing a connection that has no reality.

This is a serious matter. It is possible to talk like a Christian, attend church like a Christian, use Christian language, and even engage in Christian activities, while walking in darkness. It is possible to have the form of godliness without the power. It is possible to have the label without the life.

But the claim does not create the reality. Saying you have fellowship does not give you fellowship. Professing to know God does not mean you know God. Walking in darkness while claiming to walk in light is not just inconsistency; it is falsehood.

### **The Walk That Cleanses**

The positive side of John's statement is even more powerful: "But if we walk in the light as He is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus Christ His Son cleanses us from all sin."

#### **Notice the connections. Walking in light leads to two glorious results:**

First, fellowship with one another. When we walk in light, we are drawn to others who walk in light. There is a natural affinity, a deep connection, a genuine communion. Light recognizes light. Truth resonates with truth. Those who walk in the same direction find themselves walking together.

Second, continual cleansing. The blood of Jesus cleanses us as we walk. Not just at the moment of salvation, but continually, progressively, persistently. The cleansing is not a one-time event but an ongoing experience. As we walk in the light, the blood keeps working, keeps purifying, keeps cleansing.

This is a profound truth: the walk does not earn the cleansing, but it positions us to receive it. Walking in the light does not make us clean; it keeps us in the place where cleansing is available. It maintains the connection through which the blood flows.

## **The Nature of Walking in Light**

What does it actually mean to walk in the light? What does this look like in daily life?

Walking in light means living in honesty. It means stopping the pretense, dropping the masks, and living authentically before God and others. It means admitting when we are wrong, confessing when we have sinned, and being real about our struggles. Honesty is the atmosphere of light.

### **Walking in light means obeying God's commands. Jesus said:**

"If you love Me, keep My commandments" (John 14:15).

Walking in light is not just about believing the right things; it is about doing the right things. It is translating truth into action, turning conviction into conduct, moving from creed to deed.

Walking in light means pursuing purity. It means saying no to the deeds of darkness—the sins of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, the pride of life. It means fleeing temptation, resisting the devil, and guarding our hearts. Purity is the path of light.

Walking in light means loving others. John emphasizes this repeatedly:

"He who says he is in the light, and hates his brother, is in darkness until now. He who loves his brother abides in the light, and there is no cause for stumbling in him" (1 John 2:9-10).

Love is the evidence of light. You cannot walk in light and walk in hatred. You cannot claim to know God and refuse to love His children. Love is the proof of the walk.

### **Walking in light means following Jesus. He said:**

"I am the light of the world. He who follows Me shall not walk in darkness, but have the light of life" (John 8:12).

Walking in light is ultimately about following Him. He is the light, and as we follow Him, we walk in His light. The path is not a set of rules but a Person. The way is not a system but a Savior.

## **The Danger of Stumbling**

Walking in light does not mean we never stumble. John has already addressed this:

"If we say that we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us" (1 John 1:8).



The claim of sinlessness is as false as the claim of fellowship without obedience. We do sin. We do stumble. We do fall.

But there is a difference between stumbling in the light and walking in darkness. The one who stumbles in the light falls, gets up, confesses, and keeps walking. The one who walks in darkness falls, stays down, hides, and refuses to come to the light.

The difference is not the absence of failure but the response to it. The difference is not perfection but direction. The one walking in light, when they sin, runs to the Light. The one walking in darkness, when they sin, runs from the Light.

### **Practical Steps for Walking**

How do we cultivate a walk that stays in the light?

Start each day with surrender. Begin each morning by acknowledging your dependence on God and your desire to walk in His light. Commit your day to Him. Ask for His guidance and protection. The first steps of the day set the direction for the rest.

Stay in the Word. Scripture is a lamp to your feet and a light to your path. It shows you where to step. It warns you of dangers. It illuminates the way forward. A daily dose of divine light keeps your walk on track.

Maintain moment-by-moment prayer. Walking in light is not just about morning devotions; it is about constant communication. Throughout the day, lift brief prayers. Ask for wisdom. Seek strength. Express gratitude. Stay connected to the Source of light.

Confess sins quickly. When you stumble, do not hide. Do not minimize. Do not rationalize. Confess immediately. Bring the sin into the light. Receive the cleansing that is already available. The longer you hide, the darker your path becomes.

Stay connected to community. You cannot walk in light alone. You need brothers and sisters who will walk with you, encourage you, correct you, and hold you accountable. Isolation leads to darkness. Community keeps you in the light.

Keep your eyes on Jesus. He is the light. He is the way. He is the destination. Keep following Him. Keep gazing at Him. Keep walking toward Him. As long as you are moving toward Jesus, you are walking in light.

### **The Promise of Progress**

Walking in light is not about perfection but about direction. It is not about never falling but about always getting up. It is not about having arrived but about keeping on.

And there is promise in the walking. As you walk, you grow. As you walk, you change. As you walk, the light becomes more natural, more consistent, more characteristic of your life.

The path of the just is like the shining sun, that shines ever brighter unto the perfect day (Proverbs 4:18). The walk gets brighter as it goes. The light increases with each step. The direction determines the destination, and the destination is full and perfect light.

### **Prayer for the Journey**

Light of the world, I thank You that I do not have to walk in darkness. I thank You that You have called me out of darkness into Your marvelous light. I thank You that as I follow You, I have the light of life.

Lord, I confess that I have sometimes claimed fellowship with You while walking in ways that contradict that claim. Forgive me. Cleanse me. Restore me. Help my walk to match my talk.

Show me any darkness in my life that needs to be exposed. Bring it to light. Give me courage to confess quickly and receive Your cleansing fully. Help me to walk in honesty, obedience, purity, and love.

Keep my eyes on You. Keep me following You. Keep me walking toward You. And as I walk, let Your light shine through me to a world that desperately needs it.

I am Yours. Lead me in the path of light. In Jesus' name, Amen.

# CHAPTER EIGHT

## Lamps to the Lost

"That you may become blameless and harmless, children of God without fault in the midst of a crooked and perverse generation, among whom you shine as lights in the world, holding fast the word of life." — Philippians 2:15-16 (NKJV)

The light within you is not for you alone. It was never intended to be private, personal, or hidden. It was given to you for the sake of others. You are light so that others may see. You are a lamp so that the lost may find their way.

Paul captures this purpose in his letter to the Philippians. He describes believers as children of God living in the midst of a crooked and perverse generation. And in that context, we shine as lights in the world. The light is not for the comfort of the children but for the salvation of the world.

### The Context of Darkness

Notice first the context in which we shine: "in the midst of a crooked and perverse generation."

Paul does not assume that the world will be friendly to light. He does not expect the culture to welcome the truth. He describes the generation as crookedtwisted, bent out of shape from God's design. He describes it as perverse, distorted, corrupted, turned away from what is right.

This is the environment in which we shine. Not in a neutral world. Not in a friendly world. Not in a world that appreciates light. In a crooked and perverse generation. In a world that often prefers darkness.

### Jesus said the same:

"If the world hates you, you know that it hated Me before it hated you. If you were of the world, the world would love its own. Yet because you are not of the world, but I chose you out of the world, therefore the world hates you" (John 15:18-19).

The world's response to light is not always gratitude. Sometimes it is hatred. Sometimes it is rejection. Sometimes it is persecution. The light exposes the darkness, and those who love darkness do not thank the light for exposing them.

But we shine anyway. Not because we are naive about the world's response, but because we are faithful to our calling. The darker the world, the more needed the light.

## **The Nature of Our Shining**

What does it mean to shine as lights? How do we function as lamps to the lost?

We shine through our character. Paul begins with character: "blameless and harmless, children of God without fault."

Before we speak, our lives speak. Before we open our mouths, our character preaches. The way we live either authenticates or undermines the message we proclaim. A blameless life is a powerful sermon. A harmless character is a compelling argument.

This does not mean we are perfect. It means we are consistent. It means our lives match our message. It means there is no glaring contradiction between what we profess and how we live. The world is watching, and the world is not impressed by hypocrisy.

We shine through our message. Paul continues: "holding fast the word of life."

We do not just shine with character; we shine with content. We hold fast to the word of life—the gospel, the Scriptures, the truth that saves. This word is life because it points to the One who is Life. It is life because it contains the message that brings dead souls to life.

Holding fast means we do not let go. We do not compromise. We do not water down. We hold firmly to the truth, even when it is unpopular. We cling to the word, even when the world pressures us to release it.

We shine through our presence. Notice Paul's phrase: "among whom you shine."

The shining happens in the midst. It is not a distant light but a present light. We are not called to shine from afar but to shine among them. We are to be present in the world, engaged with the world, accessible to the world.

This means we cannot isolate ourselves from the lost. We cannot retreat into Christian bubbles and expect to shine. The light must go where the darkness is. The lamp must be placed where it can be seen.

## **The Method of Shining**

How did Jesus shine? How did He function as light in a dark world? His example provides our pattern.

He was present. Jesus did not stay in heaven. He came to earth. He dwelt among us. He lived in our neighborhoods, walked our streets, touched our lepers, ate with our sinners. He was present where the darkness was.

He was compassionate. When Jesus saw the crowds, He was moved with compassion because they were harassed and helpless, like sheep without a shepherd. His heart broke for the lost. His light was not cold and distant but warm and inviting.

He spoke truth. Jesus did not compromise the message to make it more acceptable. He spoke hard truths. He confronted sin. He called for repentance. But He spoke in love, with grace, always aiming for the restoration of the sinner.

He served. Jesus did not just preach; He washed feet. He did not just teach; He healed. He did not just talk about love; He demonstrated it. His light was not just words but deeds.

He suffered. Ultimately, Jesus' light shone brightest on the cross. In the darkest moment of history, in the deepest darkness, the light of God's love blazed most brightly. Sometimes our most powerful witness is not in our words or our deeds but in our endurance through suffering.

### **The Obstacles to Shining**

If we are honest, we must acknowledge the obstacles that keep us from shining as we should.

Fear. Fear of rejection, fear of ridicule, fear of conflict—these fears keep our light hidden. We are afraid of what people will think, so we stay silent. We are afraid of how people will respond, so we hold back.

Busyness. The urgent crowds out the important. The demands of daily life consume our energy and attention. We are too busy to notice the lost around us, too preoccupied to engage, too exhausted to shine.

Comfort. We have become comfortable in our Christian subculture. We have our friends, our activities, our routines. We have lost the urgency of reaching the lost because we are comfortable where we are.

Compromise. We have absorbed the values of the world. We think like the world, talk like the world, live like the world. There is little difference between us and those around us, so there is little light to see.

Despair. We look at the darkness and think it is too great. We look at our own weakness and think we are too small. We despair of making any difference, so we do nothing.

### **Overcoming the Obstacles**

How do we overcome these obstacles and become effective lamps to the lost?

By focusing on the One who sends us. We do not shine in our own strength. We are sent by the Light Himself. He who called us is faithful. He who commissioned us will equip us. When fear rises, remember who sent you. When despair threatens, remember who goes with you.

By remembering the value of the lost. Every person without Christ is headed for an eternity without God. This is not a minor issue. It is a matter of life and death, heaven and hell. When we truly grasp the value of a soul, we will find courage to shine.

By starting small. You do not have to reach the whole world. You just have to reach your world—your family, your neighbors, your coworkers, your friends. Start with one person. Start with one conversation. Start with one act of kindness. Small lights, consistently shone, make a big difference.

By relying on prayer. You cannot change a heart; only God can. Your job is to shine; His job is to save. Pray for the lost around you. Pray for opportunities. Pray for boldness. Prayer connects your small light to His great power.

By staying in community. You are not meant to shine alone. The body of Christ together shines more brightly than any individual. Find brothers and sisters who share your burden for the lost. Encourage each other. Pray together. Shine together.

### **The Urgency of Shining**

There is urgency in our calling. The night is coming when no one can work. The opportunity to shine will not last forever.

**Jesus said:**

"I must work the works of Him who sent Me while it is day; the night is coming when no one can work" (John 9:4).

The same is true for us. The day is now. The opportunity is present. The fields are white for harvest. But the night is coming. The time for shining is limited.

This urgency should move us. It should stir us from complacency. It should propel us into action. Not frantic action, but faithful action. Not anxious striving, but intentional shining.

### **The Joy of Shining**

Finally, we must remember that shining is not just duty; it is joy. There is no greater privilege than being used by God to bring someone from darkness to light.

### **Paul wrote to the Thessalonians:**

"For what is our hope, or joy, or crown of rejoicing? Is it not even you in the presence of our Lord Jesus Christ at His coming? For you are our glory and joy" (Philippians 2:19-20).

The souls we help reach become our joy. The people who come to light through our shining become our crown. There is joy in heaven over one sinner who repents, and there is joy on earth for the lamp that helped them find the way.

You are a lamp to the lost. The world around you is dark. People are stumbling, searching, desperate for light. You carry what they need. Will you shine?

### **Prayer for the Journey**

Lord of the harvest, I thank You that You have chosen me to be a light in this dark world. I thank You that You have placed me in the midst of people who need to see Your light. I thank You for the privilege of being used by You.

Father, I confess the obstacles that keep me from shining. My fear of what people will think. My busyness that crowds out opportunities. My comfort that makes me complacent. My compromise that dims my light. My despair that leads to inaction. Forgive me and free me.

Give me eyes to see the lost around me. Give me a heart that breaks for what breaks Yours. Give me courage to speak and to act. Give me opportunities to shine, and wisdom to recognize them when they come. Use me, Lord. I am willing. Shine through me to someone who needs to find their way to You. In Jesus' name, Amen.

# CHAPTER NINE

## The Community of Light

"But if we walk in the light as He is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus Christ His Son cleanses us from all sin." — 1 John 1:7 (NKJV)

There is a myth that has infected the modern church: the myth of the solitary Christian. It is the idea that you can follow Jesus on your own, that you can grow in faith without community, that you can shine as light in isolation.

This myth is deadly. It contradicts the entire witness of Scripture. It ignores the way God has designed us. It leads to stunted growth, vulnerability to attack, and diminished light.

John connects walking in light with having fellowship. The two are inseparable. You cannot walk in light and walk alone. Light leads to fellowship, and fellowship sustains light.

## The Design for Community

From the very beginning, God designed us for relationship. It was not good for Adam to be alone, even in a perfect world with perfect communion with God. He needed human companionship. He needed someone like himself.

The church is the fulfillment of that design. We are not merely individuals who happen to share a common belief. We are members of a body, stones in a building, branches on a vine. We are interconnected, interdependent, and inseparable.

## Paul develops this theme extensively:

"For as we have many members in one body, but all the members do not have the same function, so we, being many, are one body in Christ, and individually members of one another" (Romans 12:4-5).

Notice the phrase: members of one another. We do not just belong to Christ; we belong to each other. Our lives are intertwined. Our destinies are connected. Our growth is mutual.

## Why We Need Each Other

Why is community essential for those who carry light?



We need each other for encouragement. The journey is long. The road is hard. There are days when we are weary, discouraged, ready to quit. In those days, we need brothers and sisters who will speak hope into our hearts, who will remind us of the promises, who will lift us up when we cannot stand.

**The author of Hebrews emphasizes this:**

"But exhort one another daily, while it is called 'Today,' lest any of you be hardened through the deceitfulness of sin" (Hebrews 3:13).

Daily encouragement is not optional; it is essential. Without it, our hearts grow hard. Without it, sin deceives us. Without it, we lose our way.

We need each other for correction. We all have blind spots. There are areas of sin we cannot see, patterns of thinking we cannot recognize, errors we cannot detect on our own. We need others who will speak the truth in love, who will point out the log in our eye, who will call us back when we wander.

**Proverbs puts it plainly:**

"Faithful are the wounds of a friend, but the kisses of an enemy are deceitful" (Proverbs 27:6).

Correction from a loving friend is a gift, not an attack. It is a wound that heals, not a wound that harms. We need people who love us enough to tell us the truth.

We need each other for support. When trials come, we need people who will carry us. When burdens are heavy, we need shoulders to help bear the weight. When we fall, we need hands to lift us up.

**Ecclesiastes paints a beautiful picture:**

"Two are better than one, because they have a good reward for their labor. For if they fall, one will lift up his companion. But woe to him who is alone when he falls, for he has no one to help him up" (Ecclesiastes 4:9-10).

The solitary Christian is a vulnerable Christian. When they fall, there is no one to help them up. When they stumble, there is no one to steady them. Community provides the support system that keeps us standing.

We need each other for accountability. We are prone to self-deception. We make excuses for our sins. We rationalize our compromises. We convince ourselves that we are doing better than we actually are. We need others who will hold us accountable, who will ask the hard questions, who will expect honest answers.

**James emphasizes the importance of mutual accountability:**

"Confess your trespasses to one another, and pray for one another, that you may be healed" (James 5:16).

Confession is not just between us and God; it is between us and trusted others. When we bring our struggles into the light of community, healing becomes possible. When we hide in isolation, wounds fester.

We need each other for the exercise of gifts. Every believer has been given gifts for the building up of the body. These gifts are not for our own benefit but for the benefit of others. If we isolate ourselves, we rob the body of what we have to offer. And we rob ourselves of the joy of contributing.

**Peter writes:**

"As each one has received a gift, minister it to one another, as good stewards of the manifold grace of God" (1 Peter 4:10).

The gifts are given to be ministered. The grace is given to be shared. Isolation prevents this flow and impoverishes both the individual and the community.

**The Marks of Authentic Community**

What does authentic Christian community look like? How can we recognize it?

Authentic community is marked by love. Jesus said:

"By this all will know that you are My disciples, if you have love for one another" (John 13:35).

Love is the identifying mark. Not perfect agreement. Not identical personalities. Not similar backgrounds. Love-genuine, sacrificial, patient, kind love is the sign of true community.

**Authentic community is marked by truth. Paul writes:**

"Speaking the truth in love, we may grow up in all things into Him who is the head—Christ" (Ephesians 4:15).

Authentic community does not ignore problems or paper over differences. It speaks truth, but always in love. It addresses issues, but always for growth. It confronts sin, but always for restoration.

Authentic community is marked by humility. Paul continues:

"Let nothing be done through selfish ambition or conceit, but in lowliness of mind let each esteem others better than himself" (Philippians 2:3).

Humility is the atmosphere of community. When pride enters, community fractures. When selfish ambition dominates, relationships suffer. Authentic community requires putting others first.

Authentic community is marked by service. Jesus washed feet. He demonstrated that greatness in the kingdom is measured by service, not status. Authentic community is not about being served but about serving.

"By love serve one another" (Galatians 5:13).

Service is love in action. It is meeting needs without being asked. It is stepping into the mess of others' lives. It is giving without expecting return.

Authentic community is marked by perseverance. Real community is not fair-weather friendship. It stays when things get hard. It forgives when offenses come. It works through conflict rather than walking away.

"Bear one another's burdens, and so fulfill the law of Christ" (Galatians 6:2).

Bearing burdens means staying in the mess. It means not giving up when the burden gets heavy. It means persevering through difficulty because love perseveres.

## **The Threats to Community**

If community is so essential, we must also recognize the threats that undermine it.

Individualism. Our culture celebrates independence and self-sufficiency. We are taught to pull ourselves up by our own bootstraps, to not need anyone, to go it alone. This mindset is poison to biblical community.

Busyness. We are too busy for community. Our schedules are full. Our calendars are packed. We rush from one thing to the next, with no margin for the interruptions that relationships require.

Superficiality. We settle for shallow connections. We know many people but are known by few. We have many acquaintances but few friends. We chat about weather and sports but never share our hearts.

Conflict. When conflict arises, we run. We avoid difficult conversations. We withdraw rather than work through issues. We change churches rather than reconcile. But real community requires working through conflict, not running from it.

Independence. We do not want to be accountable. We do not want anyone asking hard questions. We want to live our own lives without interference. But community requires mutual submission and accountability.

## **Cultivating Community**

How do we cultivate authentic community in a culture that works against it?

Be intentional. Community does not happen by accident. It requires intentionality. It means prioritizing relationships, making time for people, and investing in connections. It means choosing community over convenience.

Be vulnerable. You cannot have community without vulnerability. You must let people see the real you, the struggles, the doubts, the fears, the failures. Vulnerability is scary, but it is the door to deep connection.

Be available. Community requires presence. You cannot build deep relationships in brief encounters. You need time, unhurried, undistracted time. You need to be available when people need you, not just when it is convenient.

Be committed. Community requires commitment. It means staying when you want to leave. It means working through conflict when you want to walk away. It means loving when love is hard. Commitment is the soil in which community grows.

Be grace-filled. People will disappoint you. They will fail you. They will hurt you. If you expect perfection, you will be perpetually disappointed. Community requires extending grace, forgiving offenses, and giving people room to grow.

## **The Light of Community**

When we walk in community, something remarkable happens: our light shines brighter. The body together reflects Christ more fully than any individual can alone.

The church is described as a city on a hill—not scattered individual houses but a gathered city. The light of the city is brighter than the light of any single home. The witness of the community is more powerful than the witness of any solitary believer.

Together, we display the manifold wisdom of God. Together, we demonstrate the reconciling power of the gospel. Together, we shine in ways that none of us could shine alone.

You need the community. And the community needs you. You cannot walk in light and walk alone. The light leads to fellowship, and fellowship sustains the light.

## **Prayer for the Journey**

Lord of the church, I thank You that You have not called me to walk alone. I thank You for the body of Christ, for the brothers and sisters who journey with me. I thank You that together we shine more brightly than any of us could alone.

Father, I confess that I have often isolated myself. I have tried to walk in light without walking in fellowship. I have kept people at a distance. I have hidden my struggles and pretended to be stronger than I am. Forgive me and draw me into community.

Give me courage to be vulnerable. Give me wisdom to be available. Give me commitment to persevere. Give me grace to forgive. And give me the joy of contributing my gifts to the body.

Bind me more closely to Your people. Let our light shine together. Let the world see, in our love for one another, that we are Your disciples. In Jesus' name, Amen.

# CHAPTER TEN

## Guardians of the Flame

"Take heed to yourself and to the doctrine. Continue in them, for in doing this you will save both yourself and those who hear you." — 1 Timothy 4:16 (NKJV)

The light within you is precious. It is easily dimmed and quickly extinguished if not guarded. The enemy of your soul seeks to snuff it out. The world pressures you to hide it. The flesh tempts you to compromise it. You must be a guardian of the flame.

Paul's charge to Timothy applies to every believer: Take heed to yourself and to the doctrine. Guard your life. Guard your teaching. Guard the flame within and the truth you proclaim. Continue in them. Persevere. Endure. Do not let the light go out.

### The Enemy's Strategies

To guard the flame effectively, we must understand the enemy's strategies. How does he seek to dim or extinguish the light within us?

Through persecution. When the enemy cannot seduce us, he seeks to scare us. He brings opposition, pressure, suffering. He hopes that the cost of shining will become too high, that we will hide our light to save our skin.

### Jesus warned of this:

"Then they will deliver you up to tribulation and kill you, and you will be hated by all nations for My name's sake" (Matthew 24:9).

Persecution is real. In many parts of the world, it is severe. The enemy uses fear of suffering to silence witness and dim light.

Through temptation. The enemy knows our weaknesses. He knows where we are vulnerable. He brings temptations tailored to our particular flesh. He hopes that sin will short-circuit our witness, that compromise will cloud our light.

### Paul warned the Corinthians:

"Therefore let him who thinks he stands take heed lest he fall. No temptation has overtaken you except such as is common to man; but God is faithful, who will not allow you to be tempted

beyond what you are able, but with the temptation will also make the way of escape, that you may be able to bear it" (1 Corinthians 10:12-13).

Temptation is universal. The way of escape is always available. But we must take heed. We must guard against the enemy's seductions.

Through deception. The enemy is a liar. He twists the truth. He misrepresents God. He sows doubt about what we know to be true. He whispers that sin is not so bad, that obedience is not so important, that the light can survive compromise.

### **Paul warned Timothy about this strategy:**

"Now the Spirit expressly says that in latter times some will depart from the faith, giving heed to deceiving spirits and doctrines of demons" (1 Timothy 4:1).

Deception is deadly because it does not feel like attack. It feels like insight. It feels like enlightenment. But it leads away from the light.

Through distraction. Sometimes the enemy does not need to attack directly; he just needs to distract. He fills our lives with busyness, with noise, with endless activity. He keeps us so occupied that we have no time to tend the flame. And gradually, without attention, the light grows dim.

### **Martha experienced this:**

"But Martha was distracted with much serving, and she approached Him and said, 'Lord, do You not care that my sister has left me to serve alone?'" (Luke 10:40).

The serving was good. The activity was noble. But the distraction kept her from the one thing needed. The flame within was neglected while she busied herself with good things.

Through discouragement. The journey is long. The battles are many. The setbacks are frequent. The enemy uses these to discourage us, to make us want to give up, to convince us that shining is not worth the effort.

Elijah experienced this after his great victory on Mount Carmel. Fresh from defeating the prophets of Baal, he fled from Jezebel's threat and sat under a broom tree, praying to die. Discouragement had extinguished his flame.

### **Guarding Your Life**

Paul's first charge to Timothy is: Take heed to yourself. Guard your life. Protect your soul. Tend to your spiritual health.

Guard your heart. The heart is the source of all outflow. From it spring the issues of life. If the heart is not guarded, everything else suffers. "Keep your heart with all diligence, for out of it spring the issues of life" (Proverbs 4:23).

Guarding the heart means monitoring what enters it, what you watch, what you listen to, what you dwell on. It means protecting it from bitterness, unforgiveness, and resentment. It means cultivating love, gratitude, and worship.

Guard your mind. The mind is the battlefield. The enemy attacks with thoughts—lies, doubts, temptations, accusations. If you do not guard your mind, you will be defeated in your thoughts before you ever act.

#### **Paul writes:**

"Casting down arguments and every high thing that exalts itself against the knowledge of God, bringing every thought into captivity to the obedience of Christ" (2 Corinthians 10:5).

Guarding the mind means being selective about what you think about. It means rejecting lies and embracing truth. It means taking every thought captive and making it obey Christ.

Guard your body. Your body is the temple of the Holy Spirit. What you do with it matters. How you treat it affects your ability to carry light.

#### **Paul asks:**

"Do you not know that your body is the temple of the Holy Spirit who is in you, whom you have from God, and you are not your own? For you were bought at a price; therefore glorify God in your body and in your spirit, which are God's" (1 Corinthians 6:19-20).

Guarding the body means honoring God with your physical life. It means fleeing sexual immorality. It means caring for your health. It means using your body as an instrument of righteousness.

Guard your time. Time is the currency of life. How you spend it determines what your life produces. If you do not guard your time, it will be consumed by the urgent, the trivial, and the distracting.



**Paul instructs:**

"See then that you walk circumspectly, not as fools but as wise, redeeming the time, because the days are evil" (Ephesians 5:15-16).

Guarding time means using it intentionally. It means prioritizing what matters most. It means saying no to good things so you can say yes to the best.

Guard your relationships. The people you spend time with shape who you become. They either fan your flame or quench it. They either draw you toward light or pull you toward darkness.

"He who walks with wise men will be wise, but the companion of fools will be destroyed" (Proverbs 13:20).

Guarding relationships means choosing companions wisely. It means investing in those who build you up. It means distancing yourself from those who drag you down.

**Guarding Your Doctrine**

Paul's second charge is: Take heed to the doctrine. Guard the truth. Protect the gospel. Hold fast to sound teaching.

Know what you believe. You cannot guard what you do not know. You must study the Scriptures. You must understand the doctrines of the faith. You must be able to distinguish truth from error.

"Be diligent to present yourself approved to God, a worker who does not need to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth" (2 Timothy 2:15).

Diligence in study is not optional. It is essential for guarding the truth.

Test what you hear. Not everything labeled Christian is Christian. Not every teaching that claims to be biblical is biblical. You must test everything against Scripture.

"Beloved, do not believe every spirit, but test the spirits, whether they are of God; because many false prophets have gone out into the world" (1 John 4:1).

Testing requires discernment. It requires knowing the truth well enough to recognize error. It requires the courage to reject what does not align with Scripture.

Hold fast to what is good. Once you have tested and found truth, hold it fast. Do not let it go. Do not be swayed by every wind of doctrine. Do not be moved by popular opinion or cultural pressure.

"Hold fast the pattern of sound words which you have heard from me, in faith and love which are in Christ Jesus" (2 Timothy 1:13).

Holding fast requires conviction. It requires courage. It requires commitment to truth even when it costs something.

Pass it on. The truth is not just for you. It is for the next generation. You have a responsibility to pass on what you have received, to entrust it to faithful others who will teach others also.

"And the things that you have heard from me among many witnesses, commit these to faithful men who will be able to teach others also" (2 Timothy 2:2).

Passing on the truth ensures that the flame continues. It multiplies the light. It extends the witness beyond your own lifetime.

### **The Reward of Guarding**

Paul promises a reward for those who guard the flame: "for in doing this you will save both yourself and those who hear you."

You save yourself. Not from hell salvation is by grace through faith. But from many sorrows, many regrets, many consequences of neglecting the flame. Guarding the light preserves your life, protects your soul, and keeps you on the path of blessing.

You save those who hear you. Your faithfulness becomes a means of grace to others. Your guarded life becomes a model. Your sound teaching becomes nourishment. Through you, others find the light and are saved.

The reward is both personal and corporate. It is both now and forever. It is both temporal and eternal.

### **The Promise of Preservation**

As you guard the flame, you can trust that the One who kindled it will preserve it. Your guarding is not independent of His grace; it is the means through which His grace operates.

**Jude closes his letter with a beautiful benediction:**

"Now to Him who is able to keep you from stumbling, and to present you faultless before the presence of His glory with exceeding joy, to God our Savior, who alone is wise, be glory and majesty, dominion and power, both now and forever. Amen" (Jude 24-25).

He is able to keep you. He is able to present you faultless. He is able to bring you safely home. Your guarding is empowered by His keeping. Your vigilance is sustained by His grace.

Guard the flame. It is precious. It is worth protecting. It is the light of Christ within you, and it is the hope of the world.

### **Prayer for the Journey**

Keeper of Israel, I thank You that You neither slumber nor sleep. I thank You that You are able to keep me from stumbling and to present me faultless before Your presence. I thank You that my guarding is empowered by Your keeping.

Lord, I confess that I have not always guarded the flame diligently. I have been careless with my heart, my mind, my body, my time, my relationships. I have neglected sound doctrine. I have failed to pass on the truth. Forgive me and restore me.

Make me a faithful guardian of the light within. Alert me to the enemy's strategies. Strengthen me to resist temptation, to reject deception, to overcome discouragement. Help me to guard my life and my doctrine with diligence and joy.

I trust You to keep me. I rest in Your preserving power. And I commit myself to guarding what You have entrusted to me. In Jesus' name, Amen.

# CHAPTER ELEVEN

## Shining Through Storms

"And we know that all things work together for good to those who love God, to those who are the called according to His purpose." — Romans 8:28 (NKJV)

Storms come. They are not exceptions to the Christian life; they are part of it. Jesus told us this plainly: "In the world you will have tribulation" (John 16:33). Not you might have. Not you could have. You will have.

The question is not whether storms will come, but how we will shine when they do. Will the light be extinguished by the wind and rain? Will the flame flicker and die? Or will it burn brighter, undaunted by the tempest?

The Scriptures promise that storms do not have the final word. They work together for good. They serve God's purposes. They become opportunities for the light to shine most brightly.

### The Purpose of Storms

Why does God allow storms in the lives of those who carry His light? What purpose do they serve?

Storms reveal the true foundation. Jesus told a parable about two builders. One built on rock, one on sand. The storms came to both. The difference was not in the storm but in the foundation. Storms reveal what is really there.

"But everyone who hears these sayings of Mine, and does not do them, will be like a foolish man who built his house on the sand: and the rain descended, the floods came, and the winds blew and beat on that house; and it fell. And great was its fall" (Matthew 7:26-27).

Storms test our foundation. They reveal whether our faith is genuine or merely superficial. They show us and others what we are truly made of.

Storms deepen our roots. A tree that grows in sheltered conditions develops shallow roots. It looks impressive above ground but cannot withstand strong winds. A tree that faces wind develops deep roots, anchoring itself firmly in the soil.

The same is true spiritually. Easy times produce shallow faith. Storms drive our roots deep into the soil of God's character. We learn to cling to Him when we have nothing else to cling to.

**Storms develop our character. Paul writes:**

"And not only that, but we also glory in tribulations, knowing that tribulation produces perseverance; and perseverance, character; and character, hope" (Romans 5:3-4).

Tribulation is not meaningless. It produces something. It works character into us. It shapes us into people who can persevere, who can endure, who can hope even when circumstances are hopeless.

Storms equip us to comfort others. Those who have been through storms are uniquely qualified to help others going through storms. They have experience. They have empathy. They have a testimony of God's faithfulness.

**Paul again:**

"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of mercies and God of all comfort, who comforts us in all our tribulation, that we may be able to comfort those who are in any trouble, with the comfort with which we ourselves are comforted by God" (2 Corinthians 1:3-4).

The comfort we receive becomes comfort we can give. The storms we survive become lifelines for others.

Storms display God's power. When we shine through storms, God's power is on display. Our weakness becomes the backdrop for His strength. Our frailty highlights His faithfulness. The world sees that we are sustained by something or Someone beyond ourselves.

**Paul boasted in his weaknesses because they showcased Christ's power:**

"Therefore I take pleasure in infirmities, in reproaches, in needs, in persecutions, in distresses, for Christ's sake. For when I am weak, then I am strong" (2 Corinthians 12:10).

**Examples of Shining Through Storms**

Scripture is filled with examples of those who shone through storms.

Joseph. Sold into slavery by his brothers. Falsely accused by his master's wife. Imprisoned for years. Forgotten by those he helped. Storm after storm after storm. Yet through it all, Joseph kept shining. He served faithfully in Potiphar's house. He served faithfully in prison. He trusted God even when circumstances made no sense.

And in the end, he could say to his brothers:

"But as for you, you meant evil against me; but God meant it for good, in order to bring it about as it is this day, to save many people alive" (Genesis 50:20).

The storms had a purpose. The suffering had a point. God was working all things together for good.

Job. A man described as blameless and upright, who feared God and shunned evil. Yet he lost everything—his children, his wealth, his health. His wife told him to curse God and die. His friends accused him of hidden sin. Storm upon storm upon storm.

But Job kept shining. Not perfectly. He struggled. He questioned. He complained. But he never cursed God. And in the end, God restored him and blessed him more than before.

"I have heard of You by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees You" (Job 42:5).

The storm brought deeper revelation. The suffering produced deeper intimacy.

Paul. Beaten, stoned, shipwrecked, imprisoned, hungry, cold, exposed. He endured more storms than most of us can imagine. Yet he wrote:

"I have learned in whatever state I am, to be content: I know how to be abased, and I know how to abound. Everywhere and in all things I have learned both to be full and to be hungry, both to abound and to suffer need. I can do all things through Christ who strengthens me" (Philippians 4:11-13).

Contentment in storms. Strength through Christ. Light shining in the darkest places.

Jesus. The ultimate example. He endured the ultimate storm—the cross, the wrath of God, the weight of the world's sin. In the darkest moment in history, when the sun itself refused to shine, Jesus shone brightest. His love blazed most brilliantly. His sacrifice accomplished our salvation.

"Looking unto Jesus, the author and finisher of our faith, who for the joy that was set before Him endured the cross, despising the shame, and has sat down at the right hand of the throne of God" (Hebrews 12:2).

## **How to Shine Through Storms**

What can we do to ensure that we shine through the storms that come?

Anchor in God's character. When circumstances are unstable, God is unchanging. When everything around us shakes, He remains unmoved. Anchor your faith in who He is—His goodness, His faithfulness, His love, His sovereignty.

**The psalmist wrote:**

"God is our refuge and strength, a very present help in trouble. Therefore we will not fear, even though the earth be removed, and though the mountains be carried into the midst of the sea" (Psalm 46:1-2).

If God is our refuge, we need not fear the storm. If He is our help, we can face any trouble.

Hold onto God's promises. The Bible is filled with promises for those in storms. Claim them. Meditate on them. Speak them aloud. Let them anchor your soul.

"Let us hold fast the confession of our hope without wavering, for He who promised is faithful" (Hebrews 10:23).

He who promised is faithful. The promises will not fail. Hold onto them.

Stay connected to God's people. Storms isolate us. We withdraw. We hide. But isolation makes the storm worse. We need the body. We need encouragement, prayer, and practical help.

"Bear one another's burdens, and so fulfill the law of Christ" (Galatians 6:2).

Let others bear your burden. And be ready to bear theirs when your storm passes.

Keep an eternal perspective. Storms are temporary. They last for a moment compared to eternity. What seems overwhelming now will seem small when seen from heaven's perspective.

**Paul writes:**

"For our light affliction, which is but for a moment, is working for us a far more exceeding and eternal weight of glory, while we do not look at the things which are seen, but at the things which are not seen. For the things which are seen are temporary, but the things which are not seen are eternal" (2 Corinthians 4:17-18).

Light affliction. Momentary trouble. That is how Paul saw his storms. Not because they were small, but because eternity is so vast.

Trust God's purpose. You may not understand why the storm has come. You may never understand this side of eternity. But you can trust that God has a purpose. You can believe that He is working all things together for good.

"And we know that all things work together for good to those who love God, to those who are the called according to His purpose" (Romans 8:28).

Not some things. All things. The good and the bad. The pleasant and the painful. The wanted and the unwanted. All things work together for good.

### **The Promise of Peace**

In the midst of the storm, Jesus offers peace. Not the absence of trouble but the presence of calm. Not the removal of the storm but the stillness of the soul.

"Peace I leave with you, My peace I give to you; not as the world gives do I give to you. Let not your heart be troubled, neither let it be afraid" (John 14:27).

This peace is available. It is promised. It is yours for the asking. In the storm, you can have peace.

### **The Morning After**

Storms end. They always do. The rain stops. The wind dies down. The sun comes out again. And when it does, something has changed. You have changed. The storm has done its work. You are deeper, stronger, more dependent on God, more compassionate toward others.

The morning after the storm, you see things differently. You appreciate the calm more. You value the light more. You trust the One who brought you through more.

And you are ready for the next storm, should it come. Not because you are stronger in yourself, but because you know the One who is strong in you. Not because storms are easy, but because you have learned that He is faithful.

Shine through the storm. Let the light within you burn brightest when the darkness is deepest. The world needs to see that there is a light the storms cannot extinguish.

### **Prayer for the Journey**

Lord of the storm, I thank You that You are with me in the tempest. I thank You that You do not abandon me when the waves crash and the winds howl. I thank You that Your peace is available even in the chaos.

Father, I bring my storm to You. You see it. You know it. You are not surprised by it. I ask for Your grace to shine through it. Let Your light burn brightest in my darkest moment.

Anchor me in Your character. Hold me to Your promises. Surround me with Your people. Give me eternal perspective. Help me to trust Your purpose, even when I do not understand.



I receive Your peace. I rest in Your presence. I trust Your faithfulness. And I look forward to the morning when this storm has passed and I have seen Your glory. In Jesus' name, Amen.

# CHAPTER TWELVE

## Until the Morning Comes

"There shall be no night there: They need no lamp nor light of the sun, for the Lord God gives them light. And they shall reign forever and ever." — Revelation 22:5 (NKJV)

We have journeyed together through many chapters. We have explored the light within—its source, its nature, its purpose. We have considered what it means to carry this light in every room of life: in our private world, in our families, in our workplaces, in our struggles, in our relationships.

But the journey is not over. We are still walking. The night is still here. The light still shines in darkness. And we still await the morning.

This final chapter is about that waiting. It is about living in the tension between the already and the not yet. It is about shining faithfully until the day dawns and the morning star rises in our hearts.

### The Already and the Not Yet

The Christian life is lived between two comings. Christ has come, and Christ will come again. The kingdom is here, and the kingdom is coming. We are saved, and we are being saved. We are light, and we are becoming light.

This tension is not a problem to be solved but a reality to be embraced. We live in the already—the light is within us, the Spirit indwells us, the victory is won. But we also live in the not yet—the darkness still presses, the flesh still wars, the enemy still attacks.

### Paul expresses this tension:

"For now we see in a mirror, dimly, but then face to face. Now I know in part, but then I shall know just as I also am known" (1 Corinthians 13:12).

Now we see dimly. Now we know in part. Now we carry light in earthen vessels. But then—then we will see face to face. Then we will know fully. Then the vessel will give way to the glory it contains.

### The Promise of the Morning

The Bible ends with a glorious promise: the night will not last forever. There is a morning coming when there will be no more night.

### **John describes it in Revelation:**

"And there shall be no more curse, but the throne of God and of the Lamb shall be in it, and His servants shall serve Him. They shall see His face, and His name shall be on their foreheads. There shall be no night there: They need no lamp nor light of the sun, for the Lord God gives them light. And they shall reign forever and ever" (Revelation 22:3-5).

No more curse. No more night. No need for lamps or sunlight. The Lord God Himself will be their light. This is the morning we await.

Until that morning, we shine. We shine in the darkness, knowing that the darkness is temporary. We shine with the light of Christ, knowing that the Light Himself is coming. We shine as lamps to the lost, knowing that the Sun of Righteousness will rise with healing in His wings.

### **Living in Expectation**

How do we live in expectation of that morning? What does it look like to wait well?

We live with hope. Hope is not wishful thinking; it is confident expectation. It is the anchor of the soul, sure and steadfast. It is the certainty that what God has promised, He will perform.

"This hope we have as an anchor of the soul, both sure and steadfast, and which enters the Presence behind the veil" (Hebrews 6:19).

Hope anchors us in the storms. Hope keeps us steady when everything shakes. Hope looks beyond the present darkness to the coming dawn.

We live with vigilance. Jesus told us to watch, to be ready, to stay alert. We do not know the day or the hour of His coming, but we know He is coming. And we are to live in constant readiness.

"Watch therefore, for you do not know what hour your Lord is coming" (Matthew 24:42).

Vigilance means staying awake spiritually. It means not growing dull or complacent. It means keeping our lamps trimmed and burning, ready for the Bridegroom's arrival.

We live with faithfulness. The master in the parables entrusted resources to his servants and went away. When he returned, he evaluated their faithfulness. The faithful servants were rewarded; the unfaithful one was judged.

"Well done, good and faithful servant; you were faithful over a few things, I will make you ruler over many things. Enter into the joy of your lord" (Matthew 25:21).

Faithfulness is using what we have been given for the Master's purposes. It is investing our talents, our time, our treasure in the kingdom. It is shining the light consistently, persistently, faithfully.

We live with longing. There should be in every believer a holy homesickness, a deep longing for home. Not an escapist mentality that neglects present responsibilities, but a heartfelt desire to be with the One we love.

### **Paul expressed this longing:**

"For I am hard-pressed between the two, having a desire to depart and be with Christ, which is far better. Nevertheless to remain in the flesh is more needful for you" (Philippians 1:23-24).

Longing for heaven is not morbid; it is biblical. It is the natural response of those who have tasted the goodness of God and long to taste it fully.

We live with urgency. The night is far spent; the day is at hand. The time is short. The opportunity to shine is limited. We must make the most of every opportunity, knowing that the night is coming when no one can work.

"Walk in wisdom toward those who are outside, redeeming the time" (Colossians 4:5).

Urgency does not mean frantic activity; it means intentional living. It means prioritizing what matters most. It means making every day count for eternity.

### **The Blessed Hope**

Paul calls the return of Christ the blessed hope:

"Looking for the blessed hope and glorious appearing of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ" (Titus 2:13).

The blessed hope. Not a dreaded event. Not something to fear. Something to look forward to. Something to long for. Something to anticipate with joy.

Why is it blessed? Because when He appears, we will be like Him. Because when He comes, He will wipe away every tear. Because when He returns, the night will be over and the morning will have come.

## **Until He Comes**

Until that morning, we have work to do. We have light to shine. We have love to give. We have truth to proclaim. We have lives to live for His glory.

Until that morning, we walk by faith and not by sight. We trust what we cannot see. We hold onto what we cannot feel. We believe what we cannot prove.

Until that morning, we encourage one another. We stir up love and good works. We gather together, all the more as we see the Day approaching.

Until that morning, we keep our lamps burning. We stay filled with the Spirit. We remain watchful and ready.

Until that morning, we shine.

## **The Morning Prayer**

As we close this journey together, I want to pray for you, for all of us, as we wait for the morning.

Come, Lord Jesus.

This is the final prayer of Scripture. This is the cry of the bride. This is the longing of every heart that carries the light within.

Come, Lord Jesus.

Come quickly. Come in glory. Come to take us home.

Come, Lord Jesus.

Until You come, keep us shining. Keep us faithful. Keep us watching. Keep us hoping.

Come, Lord Jesus.

The night is almost over. The day is almost here. The morning is coming.

Come, Lord Jesus.

Amen.

## **For Reflection and Application**

1. The Tension Question: How are you experiencing the tension between the already and the not yet in your life?
2. The Hope Question: What are you hoping for? Is your hope anchored in the promises of God?
3. The Vigilance Question: Are you watchful and ready for Christ's return? What would greater vigilance look like?
4. The Faithfulness Question: How are you investing what God has given you for His kingdom? Are there areas where you need to be more faithful?
5. The Longing Question: Do you long for heaven? If not, why? What might increase your longing for the morning?

## **Prayer for the Journey**

Come, Lord Jesus. This is my prayer. This is my cry. This is my deepest longing.

Until You come, keep me shining. Keep me faithful. Keep me watching. Keep me hoping. Use my light to guide others to You. Let my life count for Your kingdom.

I thank You for the light within. I thank You for the journey we have taken together through these pages. I thank You for every truth You have planted in my heart.

Now send me out to shine. Send me out to love. Send me out to serve. Send me out to wait—actively, expectantly, eagerly—for Your return.

The night is almost over. The day is almost here. Until the morning comes, I will shine.

Come, Lord Jesus.

Amen.

***LET YOUR LIGHT SO SHINE BEFORE MEN, THAT THEY MAY SEE YOUR GOOD WORKS AND GLORIFY YOUR FATHER IN HEAVEN -MATTHEW 5:16***